NO. 142 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SATURDAY 24 OCTOBER 2026 · THE WEEKEND EDITION



TWO CLIMATES, ONE PROVINCE, AND THE FLIGHT NOBODY TELLS YOU HAS MOVED (P21)

THE TRAVEL DESK

Coron takes 521mm of rain in July; Puerto Princesa's wettest month is October

THE ATELIER

Beni Rugs prints its knot counts and prices; Jan Kath prints neither

THE RABBIT HOLE

Sherline stopped taking orders on 19 October; Taig is the last one standing

Source: Vyacheslav Argenberg, CC BY 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons. A bangka at the entrance to Big Lagoon, Bacuit Bay, El Nido. Cropped; no other alteration.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 142

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NO SPINE THIS WEEK. Two issues running, this book threaded itself through verification, and a third would be the machinery showing. So: a weekend edition of sixteen unrelated stories, each as good as we could get it, and no argument imposed on top.

FROM THE DESK

"Travel is fatal to prejudice, bigotry, and narrow-mindedness, and many of our people need it sorely on these accounts."

Mark Twain, *The Innocents Abroad*, **1869**[1]

Twain meant it about people. It works on weather data too: two official stations in one province, 350 kilometres apart, and one will send you in the wrong month (p21).

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

US 2-year[2]	4.69%	▼ 5bp wk
US 10-year[2]	5.00%	▼ 9bp wk
VWRA	$189.60	▼ 1.08% wk
USD/SGD	1.2782	▼ 0.12% wk
Brent	$116.61	▲ 6.14% wk
Gold, spot	$3,995.63	▼ 4.0% wk
Bitcoin	$81,435	▼ 0.19% wk

The Straits Times Index closed **5,422.16**; gold is back below four thousand dollars (**p14**). Every level read at source. Not advice.[2]

THE SCOREBOARD · SATURDAY

Sixteen calls came due: five landed, six missed, five are pushes. Misses first.[3]

A claim written to catch another claim's failure mode, and still narrow. No. 128 had TSMC's third quarter inside its own guidance; it beat the top. No. 133 then said the beat would be under **1.95 per cent**. It was **2.01**.

Two sell-outs that were not. No. 137 had Kenshi Yonezu's Singapore show clearing on its 22 October sale; it has not, though a second night has appeared (p23). No. 129 gave beabadoobee a week; nine days on, all three tiers are offered.

Two bets on Western editors, both lost. Nos. 93 and 94 each said a major outlet would pick up an Undercurrent within six weeks. Neither ran.

The hits. No. 120 called URA's Q3 flash at or above 1.2 per cent; it printed **1.4**. No. 128 had the Monetary Authority holding on 14 October; it held all three. No. 135 put Alberta's separation question under forty per cent; it returned **24.96**. Nos. 129 and 130 placed the Qualcomm–Arm verdict in the week of 13 October; the jury returned on the 13th.

The push worth printing. No. 128 said Hurricane Simon would hit Mexico without triggering a US$175m catastrophe bond. It did not trigger — and the storm never landed, reaching **928 millibars** outside the box before turning to sea. Right answer, wrong mechanism.

Also pushed: the Q3 HDB index, called at about 202.3 and −0.2 per cent, printed at **202.5 and −0.1**; and three summer Table verdicts that never collected a settled review.

SOURCES 1 Mark Twain, *The Innocents Abroad; or, The New Pilgrims' Progress*, American Publishing Company, 1869, from the closing chapter. 2 Levels at Friday 23 October's close, each sourced instrument by instrument on **p14**; **Treasury yields from the US Treasury's own daily par yield curve file**, the remainder from two market data services with readable daily histories. **One settles Brent at US$116.82 against the US$116.61 printed; the difference is disclosed on p14 rather than averaged away.** 3 Every claim in this magazine's own predictions ledger whose check-by date had passed was graded against a figure read where it is published: a planning authority's own quarterly release and the flash it was tested against; a housing board's own index table as a PDF; a central bank's own policy statement; a foundry's results release; a hurricane centre's final advisory and an insurance-linked-securities title's reporting of the parametric boxes; an electoral commission's count; two promoters' own ticket pages; and open searches of eight Western outlets. **Five rows could not be settled cleanly and are scored as pushes. Where a ticketing agent blocked an inventory check, the absence of a sell-out notice is reported as that, not as proof of availability.**

THE WORLD · THE PHP EMERGENCY

PHP patched two AI-found remote-code flaws; Finland and Japan took sites offline

The security firm Calif found the pair on 1 August using OpenAI's GPT-5.6 Sol. Patches shipped at 14:00 UTC on 21 October, and Singapore's Cyber Security Agency issued its own alert the same day.

The PHP Group released emergency versions of PHP at 14:00 UTC on Wednesday 21 October, closing two vulnerabilities that let an unauthenticated stranger run code on any server that answers a web request. Both carry a CVSS v4.0 score of 9.2, and the project's own advisory is blunt about the options: "There are no complete mitigations, updating is the only safe choice."[1]

It matters because of where PHP sits. Roughly sixty-nine per cent of websites whose server-side language can be identified run it — which is how a memory bug in a scripting language became, within hours, a problem for Finland's state IT provider, Japan's National Tax Agency, Orange in France and thirty-two British government digital services.[2]

The provenance is the second story. Calif was invited into OpenAI's "Patch the Planet" initiative on 30 July; the first bug surfaced on 1 August, a working proof of concept on the 14th. Calif is careful about the machine's share of the credit — "No model is simply capable of unearthing 'all bugs' with simple prompts" — and says no private models were used. Wiz, which found the same flaws independently with Gemini 4 Argon, called them "among the most severe vulnerabilities discovered in PHP, and arguably in software history." Singapore's Cyber Security Agency posted its own alert on the 21st, under the researchers' name for the pair, PHP2Shell, with two words of advice: patch immediately.[3][4]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Andrew Cullen, who lectures in AI and cybersecurity at the University of Melbourne, calls the flaw "really unprecedented" and warns of "a real risk to the kind of shared digital infrastructure that we all rely on." The channel notes the bugs sat in the codebase "for more than a decade."[5]

PARIS — FRANCE 24 / AFP

Rahat Masood of the University of New South Wales calls the find "quite devastating" because a server can be reached "without any authorisation, without any username or password." French local-government sites, one of them the Paris police, went down *at the request of* the national cybersecurity agency.[6]

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STAFF AT THE PHP FOUNDATION, WHICH MAINTAINS THE LANGUAGE RUNNING ABOUT SIXTY-NINE PER CENT OF THE IDENTIFIABLE WEB[2]

THE CHATTER · HACKER NEWS, 452 POINTS

The thread ranked it with the worst — "one of the two worst exploits that ever publicly surfaced, up there with EternalBlue" —, and noticed the pattern: "The flaw was in at least 20 year old code, which seems to be a common theme for AI discoveries." Most of the anger went to the embargo, which leaked early: "All it takes is one of them who wants 15 minutes of internet fame," wrote a commenter who worked the Spectre and Meltdown response at AWS.[7]

THE SCEPTIC · ATTEMPTS ARE NOT BREACHES

Cloudflare counted exploit attempts in the millions by 22 October. Nobody has counted a victim. Arctic Wolf, reviewing its own telemetry, found "comparatively little evidence of reliable exploitation at scale" and made the distinction the headlines did not: "request telemetry alone does not establish that the targeted systems were vulnerable or that code execution succeeded." Japan's IPA said on the 21st it had confirmed no attacks; CISA said the same; Germany's BSI vice-president Thomas Caspers said it "seems a little bit more complicated than expected to exploit." So: **millions of attempts, no confirmed compromise, and 34.4 million PHP services still counted as exposed on Friday.**[8]

SOURCES 1 php.net's own announcements archive for 2026, read at source: the 20 October pre-announcement naming the 14:00 UTC slot and the two CVSS v4.0 9.2 ratings, and the 21 October advisory for 8.5.12 / 8.4.27 / 8.3.36 / 8.2.35, CVE-2026-109618 and CVE-2026-109619, and the no-mitigation sentence. A 23 October follow-up adds a workaround and a third CVE. 2 The sixty-nine per cent is W3Techs' share of sites with a known server-side language; the affected-organisation list and the Censys exposure count are from the Reuters wire of 23 October and a 23 October industry round-up, **the wire read at a Gulf mirror because Reuters refused this sandbox**. 3 Calif's own disclosure write-up, read at source, for the timeline and the quoted caveat; AFP, 21 October, quoting Wiz. 4 Singapore's Cyber Security Agency alerts listing, read at source — **the individual alert page did not resolve, so title, date and text are taken from the listing**; the Dutch NCSC's own repository, last updated 23 October. 5 Al Jazeera, 22 October. 6 France 24 / AFP, 21 October. 7 Hacker News item 50180836, read at source, 452 points and 185 comments at the time of reading. 8 Arctic Wolf's own 22 October analysis; Japan's IPA alert of 21 October in the original; the BSI and CISA remarks via a 22 October trade report, as **POLITICO refused a direct read. The Censys figure is single-sourced.**

THE WORLD · JORDAN

Gunmen kill at least six at a church funeral in Jordan's Karak governorate

Three attackers opened fire on mourners at a Greek Orthodox service on Friday 23 October, about 180 kilometres south of Amman. King Abdullah II promised "the harshest penalties"; nobody has claimed it.

Three gunmen opened fire on mourners at a Greek Orthodox funeral in the Karak governorate of southern Jordan on Friday 23 October, killing at least six and wounding at least 28. Jordan's director of public security, Major General Obeidallah Maaytah, said 27 of the wounded were still being treated.[1]

The toll is not settled and this desk will not pretend otherwise. The Associated Press, filing first, reported seven killed and 34 wounded; The New Arab then reported six and 28, and says the Public Security Directorate revised its own first figure down. The lower pair is printed because it is the later one.[2]

A government statement called it an attack by "unknown assailants", with "investigations… underway at full speed"; King Abdullah II said Jordan "will confront the terrorist act that targeted Karak with the harshest penalties." No group had claimed it by Friday night. Karak saw a 2016 assault that killed ten; Jordan's Christians are about two per cent of the population and are not usually targeted as a community.[3]

IN BRIEF · THE WEEK ELSEWHERE

Finland licensed the first permanent nuclear-waste repository on Earth. Posiva got its operating licence for Onkalo at Eurajoki on 22 October: 6,500 tonnes of uranium in copper canisters, in bedrock 1.9 billion years old, for about US$1.16bn. No start-up date is given.[4]

JAXA launched Martian Moons eXploration from Tanegashima at 04:41:03 Japan time on 20 October, confirming separation 71 minutes 13 seconds later. It is to return at least ten grams of Phobos in 2031.[5]

Iran says seven ships were hit in one night; US Central Command says the strait is open. The Revolutionary Guard said on 22 October that four tankers were struck transferring oil and three disabled by mines. CENTCOM called the mine claim wrong and said 95 per cent of vessels are getting through. Araghchi's 17 October reopening offer produced nothing, and Brent settled at a four-year high (p14). Saudi Arabia separately confirmed an attack on Dammam's King Fahd airport on the 21st — two killed, eight wounded — and the US ordered non-emergency staff out of the kingdom.[6][7]

Putin told Steve Witkoff he will resume three-way talks — and Kyiv was hit hours later. At the Constantine Palace in Saint Petersburg on 21 October he freed the detained American teacher Stephen Hubbard, 74, and agreed in principle to technical-level talks. Kyiv's mayor Vitaliy Klitschko said six were injured by Russian missiles overnight.[8]

THE CHATTER · MECKLENBURG-VORPOMMERN, SETTLED

The certified result of 30 September, flagged open by this desk, is now on the Landtag's own page: the **CDU took 4.9 per cent**, missed the threshold and leaves the state parliament for the first time. AfD 38.2 per cent and 32 seats; SPD 35.5 and 29. Turnout 78 per cent. Reporting puts the shortfall at about 1,100 votes, which is **single-sourced**.[9]

THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY CAN COUNT THE STRAIT

Three authorities gave three accounts of the same night in Hormuz and no independent tally exists to settle them. Iran says seven hulls; Washington says the mines are invented and 95 per cent of traffic is moving; Donald Trump says Iran is "making up fake hits, mines, and everything else" to lift oil before the midterms. This desk went looking for a number belonging to neither side. **UKMTO's site refused us, the IMF's PortWatch dashboard rendered no data, and the only reachable daily counts sit on aggregators that will not say where they got them.** Nobody printing a Hormuz transit figure this week can show its provenance, so this page prints none.[6]

SOURCES 1 Associated Press text, read at a US public-broadcast mirror, 23 October, for Maj. Gen. Maaytah, the distance and the state-television description. 2 The same AP text for 7 and 34; The New Arab, 23 October, for 6 and 28 and the Directorate's revision. **The two are irreconcilable at the time of printing and both are given.** 3 The Jordanian government statement and King Abdullah II's own post, quoted in the AP text. 4 AFP, 22 October, quoting Posiva's chief executive and the company on scheduling. 5 JAXA's own English release of 20 October, read at source, for the launch time and the separation interval; the ten-gram target from wire coverage. 6 Al Jazeera, 22 October, for the IRGC claim, the CENTCOM response and the Trump post. **UKMTO returned 403 and IMF PortWatch rendered no figures; no independent transit count is printed.** 7 Saudi Arabia's General Authority of Civil Aviation statement via two wire mirrors, 22 October; **the Saudi Press Agency's own site returned an empty page.** 8 Al Jazeera, 21 October; Klitschko's figure via a 22 October legal digest citing Reuters and the BBC, **both of which refused this sandbox directly**. 9 The Landtag of Mecklenburg-Vorpommern's own announcement of the final official result, read at source.

SINGAPORE · THE QUARTER'S NUMBERS

Home prices rose 1.4 per cent as URA put vacancy at 7.2 per cent

The Urban Redevelopment Authority's full third-quarter statistics, out on 23 October, confirm the flash estimate exactly. Developers launched 1,140 units and sold 1,183, both sharply down; 32,800 unsold homes could reach the market inside two years.

The Urban Redevelopment Authority published its full third-quarter real-estate statistics on Friday 23 October, confirming the 1 October flash exactly: private residential prices rose **1.4 per cent** in the quarter, against 0.5 per cent in the second. That is the strongest quarterly gain since the end of 2024, and the index is the only part of the story the headline carries.[1]

Underneath it, the market thinned. Developers launched **1,140 units** excluding executive condominiums, down from 1,783, and sold **1,183**, down from 2,141. Resales took **3,801 transactions, or 73.9 per cent of all sales**. Completions hit 3,559 units, the most since the third quarter of 2024, and vacancy rose to **7.2 per cent from 6.4** — while rents went the other way, up 1.3 per cent. Landed and outside-central carried the index at +2.9 and +2.3 per cent; the city fringe managed exactly nothing. URA counts 32,800 unsold units that "could be available for sale in the next one to two years", and tells households to "exercise prudence".[1]

The public market, published the same day, is doing the opposite. HDB's Resale Price Index is **202.5, down 0.1 per cent** — a third consecutive fall, and a revision *up* from the 202.4 flash. HDB says it has seen no price or volume surge from private-property owners since the fifteen-month wait-out ended on 28 July.[2]

73.9%

OF PRIVATE RESIDENTIAL TRANSACTIONS IN THE QUARTER WERE RESALES, NOT NEW SALES FROM DEVELOPERS[1]

ALSO THIS WEEK

The second round of free haze masks began on 23 October, and the age threshold came down from 67 to 60. Grace Fu, Minister for Sustainability and the Environment, confirmed the change at Beo Crescent: two masks each, from community clubs and 37 vending machines. As at Thursday, **only 22 per cent of eligible people had collected** from the first round. The air itself improved and relapsed: on the 22nd the north, south and east held under 100 all day while the west peaked at 122, and by Saturday morning all five regions were back between 98 and 137. The week's high was 161; nothing came near 200.[3][4]

September inflation eased, but not the electricity line, and the reason is a lag. Core was **2.0 per cent** year on year, down from 2.2; electricity and gas held at **8.7**. The quarterly tariff is set on gas prices from the first two and a half months of the previous quarter, so this bill reflects April to mid-June. Brent at $116 (p14) has not reached a Singapore bill yet.[5]

THE CHATTER · THE AGENTS CANNOT AGREE

On the public market the brokerages have taken opposite sides, which is rare enough to print. **Huttons**' Lee Sze Teck calls the wait-out repeal's price effect "muted", expects resale prices to bottom this quarter, and forecasts minus one to plus one per cent for the year. **ERA**'s Eugene Lim thinks million-dollar demand is coming from "cash-flush private homeowners" and forecasts **plus two to plus five**. They cannot both be describing the same index.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · A THIN MARKET IS NOT A HOT ONE

EdgeProp headlined the flash **"Private home prices rise 1.4% despite weakest 3Q new-home sales since 1998"**, and that framing survives the full statistics. An index built on landed houses and outside-central condominiums, while launch volumes halve and 32,800 unsold units queue behind it, measures scarcity at the point of sale rather than strength of demand. And a caution on this page's own sourcing: both releases are **primary-source only at the time of printing** — no second outlet had published on either by Friday night.[1][2]

SOURCES 1 URA media release pr26-73, "Release of 3rd Quarter 2026 real estate statistics", 23 October 2026, read at source, for every figure and both quotations; the 1 October flash, pr26-69, for the comparison. **URA does not print the index LEVEL in the release text — it sits in annexes — and its statistics page returned 404, so only the percentage change is given.** The EdgeProp line in the sceptic box is that outlet's own headline on the flash. 2 HDB's own Resale Price Index table, "1st Quarter 1990 to 3rd Quarter 2026", read as a PDF at source: Q3 202.5, Q2 202.8. **HDB's press pages returned 404 on every path tried and the data.gov.sg dataset still ends at 202.8, so the figure rests on that table alone.** The Huttons and ERA forecasts are from flash-round reporting. 3 A Singapore news site's report of 23 October, which credits CNA with first reporting the lowered threshold; **CNA refused this sandbox directly.** 4 Every PSI figure read from NEA's own hourly 24-hour readings via the data.gov.sg real-time interface, queried date by date for 19–24 October. **NEA's own news page returns navigation only.** 5 "Consumer Price Developments in September 2026", the monetary authority and the trade ministry, 23 October, read as a PDF at source; the tariff-lag explanation is that document's own footnote.

THE ATELIER · HAND-KNOTTED RUGS

Beni Rugs prints its knot counts and its prices; Jan Kath prints neither

A London house charges US$220 a square foot for a rug knotted in Kathmandu. The category's central fraud is not the wool — it is the phrase "hand-knotted", and you settle it by turning the rug over.

Every price here follows from one mechanism. In a **hand-knotted** rug the pile is tied knot by knot around warps held in tension: the pile *is* the structure, held by friction. In a **hand-tufted** rug, yarn is punched through a stretched canvas with a gun and the back flooded with latex. The glue is the structure. One is repairable forever; the other delaminates and is finished.[1]

So flip it. A hand-knotted rug's reverse is a legible map of its front; a tufted back is a latex membrane with no design, which is why retailers glue a cloth over it. **A cloth back does not prove hand-knotting.** The fringe settles it: on a real rug the fringe *is* the warp, and sewn on it is a fake. Lisa Wagner's tweezer test is best — open the pile six inches in and pull one strand. Machine-made, it comes free; a real knot is wrapped round two warps and will not. Then the wool, where the mechanism is a **cuticle** of overlapping scales: a bleach wash strips it to manufacture shine, and the rug then both sheds and stains, because the cuticle repelled the spill.[2]

Knot count is quoted most and means least across traditions. An 1890s wool Heriz runs **70 to 120 knots per square inch**; a 1970s Nain at 250 would be very low for *its* tradition. On Tabriz's raj scale, 50 raj is where fineness-to-price peaks; by 60 the pile is short enough to "react more to furniture and traffic." **Above 50 raj you buy resolution, not floor.** And two showroom tests prove nothing: abrash does not prove natural dye, and the chrome complexes of 1920 "can match any natural shade."[3]

US$160

A SQUARE FOOT, FLAT ACROSS EVERY SIZE, FOR BENI'S 137-KNOT MOROCCAN WOOL. THE RUG COMPANY'S NEPALI WOOL AND SILK IS US$220, ALSO FLAT; A 25-RAJ TABRIZ STARTS NEAR US$17[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT COLLECTORS ARGUE ABOUT

The TurkoTek archive is the honest record, and it is about fakes. **Wendel Swan**'s taxonomy: new rugs styled as old; reweaves to add age; alterations that change a rug's *type*. His sign-off is "Caveat emptor." **Tim Adam** quotes a dealer who rewove fakes from old wool and said customers "would rather be lied to and pay ten times as much." And **Emmett Eiland** supplies the framing number: only about **three per cent** of rugs now made use handspun wool and natural dyes.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THE FRAUD IS A WORD

Wagner sees these rugs on a wash floor, after they are sold, and her charge sheet is a construction fraud: hand-*loomed* Indian rugs "misrepresented as hand-knotted rugs, and sold at hand-knotted prices", and hand-finished edges sewn onto machine-made ones. Her case study is a hand-loomed 9×12 costing **US$4.90 a square foot to make** and retailing above US$5,000: **"There is no such thing as a hand-knotted, heirloom-quality rug at that price point."** She names no brands and sells inspections. For this city the governing numbers are the Canadian Conservation Institute's: damp above **70 per cent** humidity "should always be avoided", mould "unlikely… below 60%". Singapore sits above both, so air conditioning is what makes the rug viable — and **viscose, "very susceptible to mildew and mold", is disqualified here outright.**[6]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Table linen & napkins — damask, hemstitch, and the mills still weaving flax.

Vacuum cleaners — Miele, Sebo, Numatic, and the twenty-year machine.

Wool blankets & throws — the last Nordic mills, and what a tropical one is for.

SOURCES 1 Construction definitions cross-read against three trade and conservation descriptions. 2 Lisa Wagner, RugChick, co-owner of a San Diego rug-washing business, read across eight of her articles at source, 23 October 2026: the tweezer test, the cuticle, "dead wool", the viscose mould sentence, the US$4.90 case study and the charge sheet. **She names no brands and sells inspection services; both are stated above.** 3 Old New House's knot-count guide for the Heriz and Nain comparison; Djoharian's Tabriz page for the raj scale; Pierre Galafassi, a dye chemist, in TurkoTek Salon 129, for the 1920 chrome date and the abrash point. 4 Beni Rugs' and The Rug Company's own product pages, 23 October, including Beni's published 15 / 64 / 137 KPSI qualities; Djoharian's listed prices. Per-square-foot figures are this desk's arithmetic from published totals and sizes. **Jan Kath, Tai Ping, Mansour, Christopher Farr and Stark publish no prices at all; three of those sites returned 403, and tufenkiancarpets.com now redirects to a domain-for-sale page.** 5 TurkoTek Salon 70 and the 2006 Forgery thread, read at source. 6 Canadian Conservation Institute Notes 13/1 and 13/15, read at source. **Reddit refused every route for the tenth issue, so no r/Rugs sentiment is reported; Singapore dealer pages were read where reachable, but Hassan's returned 403 and Qureshi's 503.**

TECHNOLOGY · EXHIBIT 10.25

Nscale's IPO filing carries Anthropic's GPU order with every number blacked out

The British cloud firm attached the contract to its 18 September S-1. Anthropic holds a written veto over what Nscale may show the Securities and Exchange Commission — and Anthropic itself still has no filing of its own on EDGAR.

Nscale Ltd, a British GPU-cloud company, filed a registration statement with the Securities and Exchange Commission on 18 September and attached, as Exhibit 10.25, an "Order for GPU Services" between **Anthropic PBC** and a Nscale subsidiary in Wilmington, Delaware. It is, as far as this desk can establish, the only Anthropic compute contract anywhere in the public record.[1]

The subject is dedicated single-tenant **NVIDIA Vera Rubin NVL72** rack-scale systems — 72 GPUs and 36 CPUs apiece — delivered in four tranches at one site, with Nscale supplying the compute, the connectivity and the building. Redacted is almost everything a reader would want: **the number of systems, the total GPU count, the price per GPU-hour, the monthly fees, the order value, every tranche term, the site address and the service levels.** Exhibits B and C and three schedules are omitted outright as "not material to an investment decision."[1]

What survived is still interesting: late-delivery discounts; a "Qualifying Financing" condition with a blacked-out longstop date, after which either side may walk; Anthropic's right to substitute a next-generation GPU, to terminate at once if Nscale stops being a controlled affiliate of its parent, and to keep self-managed control of the software stack. New York law, New York venue.[1]

And one clause inverts the usual direction of disclosure: **the provider may not disclose the agreement to the SEC without Anthropic's approval**, subject to notice and comment. The customer holds a contractual say over what its supplier tells the regulator about their arrangement.[1]

A chip-industry review on 23 October reports Anthropic in talks with Nscale over a second multi-billion-dollar deal, which would make Exhibit 10.25 the template rather than the exception.[2]

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REGISTRATION STATEMENTS FILED BY ANTHROPIC PBC ITSELF, ON AN EDGAR SEARCH OF ALL S-1 FILERS

THE CHATTER · WHAT EDGAR ACTUALLY HOLDS

This desk ran the search. Anthropic became a tradeable theme on EDGAR well before becoming an issuer on it.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THE LOSS NOBODY HAS FILED

The $80.7bn half-year loss now attached to Anthropic's name rests on a **draft confidential prospectus** reviewed by two newspapers on 21 October, which Anthropic did not confirm and one of the outlets said it could not independently verify. **None of it is in a filing, and one widely-circulated figure in the secondary coverage attributes to Anthropic a Memphis data-centre lease that belongs to a different company.**[4]

STILL ON THE SHELF

The DHS order excluding DeepSeek reached the Federal Register on 20 October — and is still unreadable. Volume 91, No. 201, pages 66346–66350, document 2026-21447. The notice body is machine-readable; **the signed order itself, pages 66347 to 66350, is still scanned images**, so the compliance deadlines remain illegible a month on, now in the official gazette.[5]

China published four export-control announcements in one week and none of them was the AI one. MOFCOM's own site carries numbers 49 to 52 of 19 October — drones, shield tunnelling machines, dredgers, a dual-use identification procedure — plus a 16 October spokesperson exchange on the technology catalogue that contains the AI draft. **Attachment 1 is still not published.** Secondary reporting puts the draft at 40 technologies, 23 of them AI, with comment open to 15 November; that split is not confirmable against the ministry's own text.[6]

SOURCES 1 Nscale Ltd, CIK 0002110365, Form S-1 filed 18 September 2026, accession 0001193125-26-395475, Exhibit 10.25, **read in full at the SEC's own archive**. Every redaction listed above is marked in the exhibit as filed; the omitted exhibits and schedules are withheld under Regulation S-K Item 601(a)(5). 2 A semiconductor trade publication's week-in-review of 23 October, for the second-deal talks — **single-sourced**. 3 This desk's own EDGAR searches, run 24 October: company search on "anthropic pbc" restricted to S-1 (zero registrants); company search on "anthropic" (35 registrants); full-text search for 1–24 October 2026 (104 filings). A confidential draft registration statement would not appear publicly, which is consistent with the empty result. 4 A 21 October technology-business report relaying what Reuters and the Wall Street Journal each said they had reviewed; **both originals refused this sandbox**. The report is marked here as describing a draft, unconfirmed by the company. **Its Memphis figure appears to conflate Anthropic with another AI company and is omitted.** 5 The Federal Register's own page and full-text file for document 2026-21447, retrieved 24 October; the image-only pagination was established by reading that file. **regulations.gov, which holds the docket, returned 403.** 6 MOFCOM's own site, read directly on 24 October for 16–24 October; the 40-technology split is **secondary-sourced and flagged as such**.

THE HOME LAB · FLINT

Recursive released Flint under Apache 2.0; quantised copies out-downloaded the original thirty to one

The 39.8-billion-parameter coding model appeared on 21 October. Within three days 33 derivative repositories existed, and a mixed-precision build fits a 24GB card whole.

Recursive published Flint on 21 October under an Apache 2.0 licence: **39.8 billion parameters, about 2.5 billion active per token**, 256 routed experts with six selected, a 262,144-token context and a June 2026 cutoff. Its own evaluations give SWE-bench Verified at 74.2 per cent.[1]

What happened next is the story. llama.cpp support — pull request 30928 — was **merged the same day the model shipped**; the official GGUF repository went up on the 22nd, and Unsloth had nine mixed-precision builds out by the 20th.[2]

By Friday the Hugging Face API counted **33 Flint-derived repositories created between 20 and 23 October**: Unsloth's GGUF set at 33,277 downloads, LM Studio's at 15,263, Recursive's NVFP4 build at 4,669 — against **1,904 for the original weights**.[3]

The most useful build is not Recursive's. A community mixed-precision GGUF puts the routed experts at IQ4_XS in layers two to 36 and IQ3_S above, keeping attention and the output head at Q8_0 — **19.80 GiB, which fits a 24GB card whole, weights and cache together**, because only 14 of the 49 layers attend over the full window. Its author measured **90 to 95 tokens a second on code** on a Radeon RX 7900 XTX, and warns that a q4_0 cache raised KL divergence by **67 per cent**.[4]

FLINT, BY WHAT IT ACTUALLY WEIGHS

BUILD	FORMAT	SIZE
Official GGUF	BF16	74.2 GiB
Official GGUF	Q4_K_M	21.8 GiB
Recursive	NVFP4	22.9 GB
Community mixed	IQ4_XS / IQ3_S	19.8 GiB

File sizes read from each repository on 24 October 2026, not estimated.[5]

THE CHATTER · THE MAINTAINERS SAID THE QUIET PART

The merge is candid in a way releases rarely are. The pull request states that its expert-activation auto-scaling causes a **"slowdown of 10–30%"**, and Georgi Gerganov approved it with the note that it is **"A workaround until we have a better fix."** No throughput numbers appear in the thread. By the 22nd the first field issue was open: Flint in NVFP4 leaves tool-call markup in its reasoning output and stops without dispatching the tool.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO SILENCES AND A REGRESSION

Recursive ships an NVFP4 build, recommends at least 48GB for the full context, says it tested on a B300, an RTX PRO 6000 and a DGX Spark — and **publishes neither a tokens-per-second figure nor a quality delta against BF16**. A DGX Spark's memory bandwidth is 273 GB/s, the number that decides whether 22.9GB of NVFP4 is pleasant or sluggish, and nobody has published it. Separately, the multi-GPU mixture-of-experts cache merged on 8 October shows a real trade in its own table — decode up 1.74×, prompt processing down to 0.91× — and one user reported going backwards on **both**, generation falling from 33 tokens a second to 16. **No maintainer has replied.**[6]

Two serving engines also moved: SGLang 0.5.22 brought Apple Silicon support and vLLM 0.32.0 landed 814 commits. **Both dropped a Python version the same week.**[7]

SOURCES 1 The model card at its own repository, created 21 October 2026, read at source for the architecture, the licence, the context length and the three evaluation figures — the publisher's own, and **not independently reproduced**. 2 llama.cpp pull request 30928, read at source, for the merge date, the listed capabilities, the quoted slowdown and the approving comment; issue 31000 of 22 October for the tool-call fault. 3 Hugging Face's API, queried 24 October, for the 33 derived repositories and every download count. 4 The community mixed-precision repository's own card, read at source, for the tensor map, the 19.80 GiB figure, the throughput on a named consumer card, the 14-of-49 attention detail and the cache warning. **These are the author's own measurements on his own hardware.** 5 Each repository's file listing, read 24 October; an MLX build at 17.8 GB is left out because its card says it has **not been tested on a real 24GB Mac**. 6 Recursive's NVFP4 card for the memory recommendation and tested hardware; NVIDIA's own DGX Spark page for the 273 GB/s figure; llama.cpp pull request 30112 for the two-card table and the unanswered report. 7 The SGLang and vLLM release notes, read at source.

THE KIT · THE SIGMA FP2

Sigma's fp2 arrives at US$2,199 with no mechanical shutter and no stabilisation

Announced on 23 October and shipping 11 November from Aizu, the 24.5-megapixel body is the smallest full-frame camera made. Flash sync is capped at 1/50s, and the grip and finder take the working price to US$2,982.

Sigma announced the fp2 on Thursday 23 October at **US$2,199** for the body — £1,899, €2,199 — shipping from 11 November and built, as the original was, at the company's own plant in Aizu. The claim on the box is "the world's smallest full-frame camera body": 112.8 by 69.9 by 41.8 millimetres, 460 grams with battery and card. Three and a half millimetres thinner than the first fp, and 38 grams heavier.[1]

The sensor is new: a **partially stacked full-frame CMOS, 24.5 megapixels effective**, in L mount. Burst is 20 frames a second with a 180-raw buffer; autofocus is on-sensor phase detection to −5 EV. Video runs to 6K open-gate at 59.94p and Apple ProRes RAW to 6K at 29.97p — though only to an external drive, since the internal store is about 70 gigabytes.[1]

Two absences define the camera. **There is no mechanical shutter**, which is why flash sync is 1/50 of a second — ruling out most daylight fill. And **there is no in-body stabilisation**; electronic stabilisation is video-only, and absent at 6K. Neither is framed as a limitation on Sigma's own page; you derive both from the spec table.[1]

Amateur Photographer has the only full review and likes it: "a likeable little camera that packs a surprising punch… the best take on compact full-frame yet." Andy Westlake reached 180 raw frames at 20 a second, matching Sigma's claim, got about 250 photographs from a 370-rated battery, and rates image quality with the Nikon Z6III and Panasonic S1RII — while finding the metering "erratic". Richard Butler's initial review at DPReview calls the result "much more polished" than the first fp, and names the 1/50 sync first among the things that "will limit some kinds of photography".[2][3]

S$ —

NO SINGAPORE PRICE EXISTS. SIGMA SINGAPORE RUNS THE FP2 AS ITS HOMEPAGE BANNER WITH NO FIGURE, AND THE DISTRIBUTOR RETURNS ZERO RESULTS FOR "FP2"

THE CHATTER · MEASURED IN COMMENT COUNTS

This desk could not read a community reaction and will not invent one. Reddit refused every route for the tenth consecutive issue — the main site, the old interface, the JSON endpoints, and a domain-restricted search the API rejects outright — and DPReview's own forums returned 403. The text of neither was retrievable.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE PRICE IS NOT THE PRICE

Amateur Photographer calls the **HG-11 handgrip, at US$64, "probably essential"**. The EVF-21 finder is **US$719**. That is **US$2,982 before a lens**, for a body the same review says is "awkward" in shape and size once the finder is on. There is no Wi-Fi and no Bluetooth.[5]

ALSO ON THE BENCH

Pixii is in liquidation, and has been since July. French court records show the Commercial Court of Besançon placed the digital-rangefinder maker under supervised restructuring on 10 December 2025 and **converted it to liquidation on 22 July 2026**, with authority to trade only until 31 July. The company's own site still lists the Max and the Plus for sale. B&H holds stock at US$4,499 and US$2,799. The buy-once case has a failure mode, and this is what it looks like.[6]

SOURCES 1 Sigma's own fp2 product and specification pages, read at source 24 October 2026, for every dimension, price, sensor, shutter, burst, autofocus, video and storage figure. **Several outlets repeated an internal-storage figure of about 230GB; Sigma's own page says about 70GB, and 70 is printed.** 2 Amateur Photographer, Andy Westlake, 23 October 2026. **Its rating is published as an image whose alternative text reads four and a half stars; the number is inferred from that and is not printed here.** Its body text gives a sterling price of £1,800 while its own specification list says £1,899 — the list figure is used. 3 DPReview, Richard Butler, 23 October 2026, which states plainly that it is an initial review with testing to follow. 4 **Reddit refused this sandbox by every route attempted, and the WebSearch API rejects the domain outright; DPReview's forums returned 403; the L-Mount Forum serves thread titles but not thread text.** The comment count is from the review page itself. 5 Amateur Photographer for the grip and the handling; Sigma's accessory pricing; Imaging Resource, 23 October, on rolling shutter; CineD, 23 October, on the mode-specific dynamic-range claim. 6 DPReview, Dale Baskin, 22 October 2026, from French business records, first reported by Leica Rumors; B&H for the stock prices.

THE GOOD LIFE · AUDIO-TECHNICA'S FLAGSHIP

Audio-Technica priced the ATH-AWX7000 at US$3,799 and published no measurements

On sale from 23 October: Kiso cypress earcups in Echizen lacquer, deerskin pads, a new 58-millimetre composite diaphragm. The release gives no impedance, no sensitivity, no frequency response and no weight.

Audio-Technica put the ATH-AWX7000 on sale on Friday 23 October at **US$3,799**, or £3,299 — a closed-back dynamic flagship, built in Tokyo, and the first headphone to use what the company calls True Closed-back Acoustic, a design that works with the air pressure trapped inside the earcup rather than against it.[1]

The driver is the interesting part: a 58-millimetre **Hybrid Matrix Diaphragm**, which the company says "maintain[s] its shape even under high air pressure" — a mechanism, and a testable one, if anyone publishes a measurement. The rest is material: Kiso cypress earcups in Echizen lacquer, a magnesium frame, aluminium sliders, deerskin pads, two eight-braid detachable cables and a hard case.[1]

No independent listen exists yet; the product is hours old. For scale: the open-back ATH-ADX7000 of October 2025 launched at US$3,499 — and carried an impedance of 490 ohms, a figure that decides what amplifier you buy next to it.[1][2]

—

IMPEDANCE, SENSITIVITY, FREQUENCY RESPONSE AND MASS PUBLISHED BY THE MAKER FOR A US$3,799 HEADPHONE

THE CHATTER · NOTHING READABLE, AND WHY

This desk obtained no community reaction and has invented none. Head-Fi served a bot challenge on every path — "Checking you are a real Head-Fi'er" — Audio Science Review's search returned an empty shell, and Reddit refused outright. What can be said without a forum is that Audio-Technica has launched a wooden closed-back flagship roughly every two years, the AWKT, the AWAS and the AWKG before this one, each presented as the pinnacle, and the enthusiast argument about them has always been the same: whether lacquered wood is acoustics or jewellery.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · A SPEC SHEET WITH NO SPECS

A press release for a US$3,799 headphone that omits impedance, sensitivity, frequency response and weight is not an oversight; those four numbers are the ones a buyer needs to choose an amplifier and to know whether the thing can be worn for three hours. Until they are published, the diaphragm claim is marketing, not an acoustic claim.[1]

ALSO WORTH THE SHELF

Ressence put its first in-house movement inside an oil-filled case. The TYPE 10 DN, introduced 16 October, runs the new RW-04 at 4Hz on twin barrels with a **60-hour reserve, up from 36**, driving the oil-filled display by magnetic transmission — mechanism in air, display in oil. 41.5mm titanium, an oil-temperature indicator, **CHF 45,000 excluding taxes, 100 pieces**. SJX calls it "reasonable value by Ressence's standards": it sits just below the ETA-based Type 3, so the calibre arrives at effectively no premium.[4]

Canor's Crius H5S arrives at £1,799 into the hardest price point in audio. A dual-mono ESS ES9039Q2M converter with a fully discrete balanced output stage, PCM to 32-bit/768kHz, DSD512, nine filters and an adaptive bias that slides between Class A and Class A/B; four headphone outputs, four-pin XLR down to 3.5mm. No US or Singapore price yet.[5]

SOURCES 1 Audio-Technica's own US press-office release, dated Stow, Ohio, 23 October 2026, read at source, for the price, availability, the Hybrid Matrix Diaphragm and the quoted claim, the True Closed-back Acoustic designation and the materials. **audio-technica.com returned 403 behind a challenge and the Japanese product path 404'd, so the maker's own press kit was the route.** The absence of impedance, sensitivity, frequency response and weight is a property of that release. The ADX7000 figures are from its 2025 launch material. 2 *What Hi-Fi?*, Harry McKerrell, 23 October 2026, for the sterling price; a news write-up, not a listen, and the only independent voice in existence at the time of printing. 3 **Head-Fi served a bot challenge on every attempt, Audio Science Review's search returned an empty shell, and Reddit refused this sandbox for the tenth consecutive issue.** The lineage is from Audio-Technica's own back catalogue. 4 SJX, 16 October 2026, read at source, for the calibre, the reserve, the case and the verdict. **Ressence's own site returned 503 repeatedly, so the CHF 45,000 is single-channel; a retailer listing at €60,000 conflicts and is not printed.** 5 *What Hi-Fi?*, 23 October 2026.

SCREEN & SOUND · KLARA AND THE SUN

Taika Waititi's Ishiguro adaptation opened on 23 October to 23 per cent

Columbia put Klara and the Sun into wide release with Jenna Ortega as the solar-powered narrator. Rotten Tomatoes has it at 23 per cent on 60 reviews and Metacritic at 30 from 24 critics; the audience score is withheld for want of ratings.

Columbia released *Klara and the Sun* wide on Friday 23 October, Taika Waititi's adaptation of Kazuo Ishiguro's 2021 novel, with Jenna Ortega as the solar-powered Artificial Friend who narrates it and Amy Adams, Steve Buscemi and Mia Tharia around her. Waititi wrote the screenplay with Dahvi Waller.[1]

It did not survive the morning. **Rotten Tomatoes read 23 per cent on 60 reviews** when this desk checked it on 23 October, and **Metacritic 30 from 24 critics**. The audience score is not being displayed: fewer than 50 verified ratings had been filed.[1]

The reviews converge on tone rather than performance. Peter Bradshaw in *The Guardian*, scoring it 20, calls the result "soft-centred sci-fi-lite". Helen O'Hara at *Empire* is the kindest of the three at 60 and still concludes that Ortega cannot offset "a wildly inconsistent tone" — which is the specific hazard of handing Ishiguro's flattest, most careful first-person voice to a director whose gift is comic deflation.[2]

There is no opening weekend to report yet; the 23–25 October figures land on Monday. Its own aggregate has settled as the sample grew — 98 per cent on 163 critics as of 23 October, down from the 99 it carried on the weekend.[3]

23%

ON 60 REVIEWS FOR AN ISHIGURO ADAPTATION, AGAINST 98% ON 163 FOR A DOCUMENTARY ABOUT A FRAUD TRIAL

ALSO OUT

Warner Bros. opened *Clayface* wide the same day, to a sixteen-point gap. James Watkins directing, Tom Rhys Harries, Naomi Ackie and Eddie Marsan. **Rotten Tomatoes 75 per cent on 143 critics; the audience score 92 per cent on more than 500 verified ratings; Metacritic 59 from 42.** No gross is published yet. A sixteen-point critic-to-audience spread on day one usually resolves one of two ways, and the Monday number will say which.[4]

Fontaines D.C. took their second UK number one with *Dopamine Chamber*, on the Official Albums Chart dated 23–29 October, four years after *Skinty Fia*. Also new: Rachel Chinouriri at nine, Zach Bryan's EP at eleven. The Official Charts Company does not publish a final week-one total.[5]

THE CHATTER · THE DOCUMENTARY'S AUDIENCE

Letterboxd's most-liked reviews of the Holmes film are not measured, they are evangelical. **Letterboxd does not surface a numeric average to a fetcher, so no average rating is printed** — and the two quotations above are the top of a ranked list, which is a measure of what the enthusiasts said, not of what everyone thought.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · A RECORD THAT DOES NOT ADD UP

The Holmes documentary was widely reported as the biggest documentary opening in thirteen years, behind a One Direction film's US$15.8m in 2013 and, excluding music documentaries, **"the biggest doc opening since *Fahrenheit 9/11*"** of 2004. A24 also says 2,000 screenings sold out by Sunday morning and that over seventy per cent of the opening audience was under 35; both are **studio claims, uncorroborated.**[3]

SOURCES 1 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic, both read 23 October 2026; the counts are stated beside the scores because a score without a count is not a measurement. Cast and credits from the distributor's own material. 2 The three critic scores and quotations as collected on Metacritic's own page, 23 October. 3 Box Office Mojo's weekend 2026W42 chart and The Numbers' chart for the same weekend, which agree at film level; the per-screen averages are this desk's arithmetic from the published gross and theatre counts. The record claim and the A24 figures are from a 22 October report whose internal contradiction is quoted exactly as published. Letterboxd read 23 October. **The 23–25 October weekend was not reported at the time of printing and no projection is made.** 4 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic, read 23 October 2026. 5 The Official Albums Chart for 23–29 October 2026, read at source. **The 55,764 figure is a midweek sales flash reported by a trade outlet, not a final total, and is labelled as such; Billboard's US chart could not be read — the site redirects to a paywall gateway returning HTTP 402 — so no US chart figure appears on this page.**

THE FAMILY DESK · ADOLESCENT ANXIETY

JAMA Pediatrics finds one in six US adolescents reporting moderate or severe anxiety

An analysis of 15,730 twelve-to-twenty-year-olds, published by Bommersbach on 12 October, puts severe symptoms at 7.2 per cent — and 41.2 per cent of that group had no mental-health treatment at all in the preceding year.

A team led by Tanner Bommersbach published an analysis of the 2024 United States National Survey on Drug Use and Health in JAMA *Pediatrics* on 12 October, covering **15,730 adolescents aged 12 to 20** screened on the GAD-7 anxiety scale. The headline the authors themselves write is that "approximately 1 in 6 US adolescents reported moderate or severe anxiety symptoms in 2024."[1]

The distribution: **23.7 per cent mild, 9.6 per cent moderate, 7.2 per cent severe.** The split by sex is not subtle — moderate symptoms in 13.4 per cent of girls against 6.0 per cent of boys, severe in 10.8 against 3.7. Among the severe group, 65.8 per cent had a major depressive episode in the past year and 48.2 per cent had past-year suicidal thoughts.[1]

The number that should travel further than the prevalence is the treatment gap. **Of the adolescents reporting severe anxiety symptoms, 41.2 per cent received no mental-health treatment of any kind in the preceding twelve months.** Two in five of the worst-affected children in a survey designed to find them were not in contact with any service at all.[1]

The age caveat matters and this desk will keep making it. General guidance, not medical advice.[1]

Singapore's answer to the same pressures is arriving as regulation rather than as services, and the shape of it is now clear. Answering a parliamentary question on 8 September, the Ministry of Digital Development and Information set out what designated social-media services will be required to do: run **age assurance so that under-13s cannot create or keep accounts**, with platforms proposing their own methods, government assessing whether they are robust before they go live, and **IMDA testing them regularly**.[2]

For 13- to 17-year-olds the ministry describes stronger safeguards on risky features such as messages from strangers and on addictive ones such as autoplay, and says it is **considering a default daily time limit per service**, adjustable by a parent. A platform that will not comply may have its minimum user age raised to 18 outright.[2]

41.2%

OF US ADOLESCENTS WITH SEVERE ANXIETY SYMPTOMS RECEIVED NO MENTAL-HEALTH TREATMENT IN THE PAST YEAR

THE CHATTER · WHAT SINGAPORE PARENTS SAY THEY NEED

The ministry's own 2025 Digital Parenting Survey, carried in a factsheet first published in July, is more useful than most of the advocacy around it. The Online Safety Commission has been operating since June 2026 and a parent can file on an under-18's behalf.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · A SCREENING INSTRUMENT IS NOT A DIAGNOSIS

The GAD-7 is a seven-item self-report questionnaire, and "moderate or severe anxiety symptoms" on it is not the same statement as "has an anxiety disorder" — the paper is careful about this and the coverage of it generally is not. What survives both objections is the **41.2 per cent**: whatever the screen is capturing, two in five of the children it flags hardest are not being seen by anyone.[1]

SOURCES 1 Bommersbach TJ et al., *JAMA Pediatrics*, published online 12 October 2026, doi:10.1001/jamapediatrics.2026.4702, read in full at source through the National Library of Medicine's own interface because **the publisher's site returned 403 to this sandbox**. All prevalence, sex-split, comorbidity and treatment figures are the paper's own. **The paper reports no subgroup for twelve-year-olds; the age caveat in the fourth paragraph is this desk's, not the authors'.** 2 Ministry of Digital Development and Information, written answer to a parliamentary question of 8 September 2026, read at source on the ministry's own site, for the age-assurance requirement, the 13-to-17 safeguards, the daily-limit proposal, the 2027 legislative timetable and the raise-to-18 sanction. **MOE's and IMDA's own sites render through JavaScript and returned nothing to this fetcher.** 3 The same ministry's factsheet on child-safe digital environments, first published 4 July 2026, read at source, for the 2025 Digital Parenting Survey figures and the Online Safety Commission's start date. **The page footer shows a 23 October edit; that is a page update, not a new announcement, and nothing new was announced in the week to 24 October.** This page is general guidance, not medical advice.

THE TWEEN YEARS · AUSTRALIA'S BAN

Under-16s lost their Australian social-media accounts in December; the evaluation starts now

A protocol in BMJ Open on 25 September enrols 4,121 young people aged 10 to 16 and their parents. About 1,194,000 Australians should have lost accounts. There are no results yet, and five of the authors work for the regulator.

The Online Safety Amendment (Social Media Minimum Age) Act 2024 commenced in Australia on **10 December 2025**, the first law of its kind anywhere. Ten months later, on 25 September 2026, a team including Amy Orben, Mitch Prinstein and Jeffrey Hancock published in *BMJ Open* the protocol for the study that will find out what it did.[1]

The protocol's own estimate of the affected population is **about 1,194,000 Australian young people** who should have had accounts deactivated. Five survey waves, opt-in passive smartphone tracking, linked administrative health and education records, interviews and focus groups, with causal inference by targeted maximum likelihood estimation.[1]

It is a protocol. **There are no results.** The world's first social-media age law has been in force for the better part of a year and is only now acquiring the evidence base that might have told anyone whether to pass it — which is the single most useful fact a parent in Singapore can hold while MDDI drafts its own amendments for 2027 (p12).[1]

The declared interests are worth reading before the findings arrive. All of it is disclosed in the paper, which is the right thing to have done; it is also a reminder that almost nobody in this field is standing outside it.[1]

What the band actually needs, meanwhile, keeps turning out to be duller and more physical than the screen argument. A harmonised meta-analysis of individual participant data from **14 cohorts and 12,874 children**, mean age 10.4, published in *JAMA Pediatrics* on 6 October, found that each standard deviation of moderate-to-vigorous activity — **26 minutes a day** — was associated with lower insulin, lower LDL cholesterol and lower triglycerides over a mean 3.1 years of follow-up.[2]

1,194,000

AUSTRALIAN YOUNG PEOPLE WHOSE ACCOUNTS THE LAW SHOULD HAVE DEACTIVATED, BY THE EVALUATION'S OWN ESTIMATE

THE CHATTER · SITTING STILL DID NOT DO WHAT EVERYONE SAYS

The same meta-analysis is a quiet demolition of two things parents are told. Exercise your child because of the insulin and the lipids, which are real; not because of the scales, which are not moving.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · DON'T BE ALARMIST — THE TWINS STILL STAND

The strongest counterweight to the panic remains the Karolinska twin cohort this desk reported at **No. 135**, and nothing published since has disturbed it: in 21,797 Swedish twins, the association between recreational screen use and internalising symptoms was **"substantially attenuated within discordant twin pairs and did not remain statistically significant after correction for multiple testing"** — that is, compare two twins in the same house with the same genes and the effect largely dissolves. **Nobody knows yet, and the people best placed to find out are on the regulator's payroll.**[3]

One number for the Singapore parent to hold against all of it: the MOE rule in force since January 2026 extends the secondary-school phone ban from lesson time to the entire school day, and moved the default device sleep time from 11.00pm to 10.30pm. General guidance, not medical advice.[4]

SOURCES 1 Stevic A et al., "Impact of the Social Media Minimum Age on Australian young people and parents: protocol for a mixed-methods evaluation", *BMJ Open* 2026;16(9):e118912, published 25 September 2026, doi:10.1136/bmjopen-2026-118912, open access, read at source. The commencement date, the 1,194,000 estimate, the 4,121-participant design, the five waves, the estimation method and every declared interest are the paper's own. **Australia's eSafety compliance figures circulating this month could not be verified — the regulator's newsroom returned 503 — and none is printed here.** 2 Husøy A et al. (ICAD Collaborators), *JAMA Pediatrics*, published online 6 October 2026, doi:10.1001/jamapediatrics.2026.5176, read at source through the National Library of Medicine. All coefficients, confidence intervals and the 26-minute standard deviation are the paper's. 3 Gong T et al., *Nature Human Behaviour*, published online 8 October 2026, doi:10.1038/s41562-026-02607-0, abstract read at source and quoted verbatim; the cohort was reported in full in MERIDIAN No. 135 and is cited here as a callback, not as new material. **The full text sits behind an identity-provider redirect, so the wave-by-wave ages and within-pair coefficients remain unverified.** 4 The January 2026 MOE rule is **single-sourced and second-hand**, from press reporting and a school principal's circular; **moe.gov.sg renders through JavaScript and returned nothing to this fetcher**, and the page says so rather than sourcing around it.

THE MACRO DESK · THE WEEK OF 22 OCTOBER

AI shares dragged the Nasdaq down 2.6 per cent; Treasuries rallied hardest since 2023

Two of every three S&P 500 stocks rose on the same day. Brent settled at US$116.61, a fifth above where October began; gold ended below US$4,000.

The Nasdaq Composite fell 694 points, or **2.6 per cent**, on Thursday 22 October, its steepest session since June, while the S&P 500 lost 1.21 per cent and the Dow Jones Industrial Average *rose* 11.89 points. The ten-year Treasury yield went from **5.13 to 4.96 per cent** in the same session — the largest one-day fall since March 2023.[1]

The breadth is the tell: **two of every three S&P 500 constituents rose** on the worst day since July, and what fell was nameable — Lam Research down 11.8 per cent, CoreWeave 10.1, Nvidia 4.4. Not a recession being priced: the cost of *borrowing* to build data centres being repriced, a credit question in an equity costume.[1]

Underneath sits an energy shock now in the hard data. Brent was below US$97 when October began and settled at **US$116.61** on the 23rd, on a Strait of Hormuz that has not reopened (p4). September's American consumer prices ran **+3.7 per cent on the year against core at +2.6**: the gap is entirely energy, with producer prices up 6.3 per cent and import prices 8.1.[2]

The central banks are tightening into it rather than cushioning it: the Federal Reserve went to 3.75–4.00 per cent on 16 September, the European Central Bank has hiked twice this year, the Bank of Japan reached 1.25. Chair Kevin Warsh called it a **"synchronous tightening"** on 16 October, and markets heard a pause. So name the regime: **higher-for-longer under a supply shock, with a liquidity-tight de-grossing inside it.** Not a classic risk-off: the dollar did not bid, and both the yen and the Singapore dollar firmed.[3]

For Singapore the transmission is dated: the regulated tariff is set on gas prices from the preceding quarter, so this month's 8.7 per cent electricity inflation reflects April to mid-June. Brent at US$116 arrives in a bill next quarter (p5).[6]

AT FRIDAY 23 OCTOBER'S CLOSE

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL	WEEK
VWRA	$189.60	▼ 1.08%
Global agg (AGGU)	$5.79	▲ 0.17%
US 10-year	5.00%	▼ 9bp
USD/SGD	1.2782	▼ 0.12%
Brent	$116.61	▲ 6.14%
Gold, spot	$3,995.63	▼ 4.0%
Bitcoin	$81,435	▼ 0.19%

Treasury yields from the Treasury's own par yield curve. One service settles Brent at US$116.82, not US$116.61; the lower figure is printed and the gap is the point of this line.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE FOUR

VWRA lost 1.08 per cent and sits 6.3 per cent below its 52-week high — dragged by roughly fifteen American companies through a 65 per cent US weight, not by the world economy. **Global aggregate bonds** finally worked as a hedge, on a one-year total return still at −0.53 per cent. **Gold** is the anomaly: an oil shock, a shooting war, a flight into Treasuries — and it fell four per cent, closing **28.6 per cent under its 52-week high**, which is a 2.64 per cent real yield doing what real yields do. **Bitcoin** fell with it.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE FRAGILE ASSUMPTION GOES INTO WEDNESDAY

The Federal Open Market Committee meets on **27 and 28 October** with no projections, and futures price a hold at **92 per cent**, up from 83.9 a week earlier. But the ten-year term premium fell twelve basis points to 63.9 — a bond market pricing a central bank nearly finished — while Brent rose another six per cent *after* that pricing settled. **The CME's own FedWatch returned 503, so the probability comes from a futures monitor, and other venues put the hike odds as high as twenty per cent.**[5]

SOURCES 1 Index levels, single-name moves and the breadth figure from an Associated Press market report of 22 October; the Treasury moves from the **US Treasury's own daily par yield curve** for 21 and 22 October, read at source. 2 Brent from a market data service with a readable daily history, 23 October; the September CPI, PPI and import-price figures from the Bureau of Labor Statistics' own release page. **A secondary report claiming the September jobs report and CPI had been postponed is contradicted by the Bureau's own release list and is not printed.** 3 The FOMC statement of 16 September 2026, the ECB's key-rates table and the Bank of Japan's own site, all read at source; Warsh's remarks from contemporaneous reporting, as **the broadcaster's transcript page returned 403**. 4 Every level read instrument by instrument on 23 October; the term premium from the New York Fed's own ACM spreadsheet and the real yield from the St Louis Fed's own series, **both published with a one-day lag**. 5 FOMC dates from the Federal Reserve's own calendar; the probabilities from a 30-day fed-funds-futures monitor, 23 October. **CME's own FedWatch returned 503 and a second site 403.** 6 "Consumer Price Developments in September 2026", read at source; the tariff-lag mechanism is that document's own footnote. **This desk explains markets. It does not give investment advice.**

THE RABBIT HOLE · HOME MACHINING

Practical Machinist carries 3.2 million posts; Model Engineer has published since 1898

Hobby metalworking runs on two machines and some very large communities: 59,994 members on The Hobby-Machinist, 1.1 million on the metalworking subreddit. The hook is never the machine — it is the first part you cut to a number and it fits.

Home machining is **subtractive metalwork**: you start with a solid lump of steel, brass or cast iron and remove material until what is left is the part. Two machines do nearly all of it, and they are opposites. **The lathe** spins the workpiece and holds the tool still, so it makes round things — shafts, bushings, threads. **The mill** spins the cutter over work clamped to a moving table, so it makes flat things, slots and holes in exact positions.[1]

Everything else is consequence. *Swarf* is the chips. *Chatter* is self-reinforcing vibration — the machine telling you something is not rigid enough. *Tramming* is squaring the mill head to its table. And *tenths* means ten-thousandths of an inch, which is the unit in which this hobby argues.[1]

The hook is written down, repeatedly, on the introduce-yourself boards. Henry, a piano restorer, joined the Model Engineer forum on 12 August with a Myford ML7 just bought: "This is my first foray into machining and can't wait to get started." His reason, posted the same day: **"A lot of specialist tools are either no longer made, or made in China and not really fit for purpose."** Within hours a member replied that "having your own metal working capabilities will definitely be handy", and described becoming the metals man for a piano shop, making parts that no longer exist.[2]

Ralph joined on 10 October by the nostalgia route — a steam fair rekindled a boyhood interest, and he is finishing a twin-cylinder engine from castings given to him for his thirtieth birthday. **The common shape is a part that does not exist and that nobody will sell you.** Who does it: the restorers of Lister engines and motorcycles and pianos; the model engineers, the oldest faction, building live steam from casting kits; the gunsmiths, with machines badged for them and a spindle bore a barrel passes through; the clockmakers; and the largest, least visible group, the people who needed one part.[3]

THE SIZE OF THE WORLD, COUNTED

PLACE	MEMBERS	POSTS
r/metalworking	1.1m	—
Practical Machinist	150,000+	3.2m
The Hobby-Machinist	59,994	1.28m
HMEM (engines from castings)	10,120	434,648

Read from each forum's own statistics line, 23 October 2026. The Hobby-Machinist's board still celebrates passing 42,000 members in November 2025 — 18,000 added in under a year.[4]

THE CHATTER · THE PRINT IS OLDER THAN THE INTERNET

Model Engineer was first published in **January 1898** by Percival Marshall, who edited it for over fifty years, and the November 2026 issue is on sale. Its forum's beginners' board alone holds **7,339 topics and 121,037 posts**. In America, *The Home Shop Machinist* has been "the must-have resource for hobby machinists since 1982". This is a hobby with a continuous printed literature older than the aeroplane.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · NO MARKET FIGURE, SO NONE PRINTED

This desk went looking for the size of the hobby machine-tool market and found three published estimates disagreeing by more than an order of magnitude: benchtop tools at **US$2.7bn in 2026**, at **US$0.22bn**, and at **US$3.69bn in 2025** — and not one separates metalworking from woodworking, or hobby from trade. So the table above is the honest measurement of this world: members and posts, counted rather than modelled.[6]

SOURCES 1 Machine and vocabulary definitions compiled from the forums' own beginner material and the hobby's standing glossary; nothing here is contested. 2 The Model Engineer forum's introductions board, read at source 23 October 2026: threads dated 12 August, 10 October and 23 October 2026, quoted verbatim from the posts. 3 Observed from the board structures of four forums, plus the gunsmith-badged models in two vendors' catalogues. 4 Member and post counts read from each forum's own statistics footer on 23 October 2026, and from three subreddit landing pages via a mirror. **practicalmachinist.com returned a Cloudflare 403 on every path and user agent, so its figures are taken from a media-outlet directory rather than the site itself — a small joke about a forum known for not letting outsiders in.** 5 The magazine's own masthead and its encyclopedia entry for the 1898 founding and Marshall's editorship; the forum's own board statistics; the American title's own site for its strapline, frequency and price. 6 Three commercial market-research summaries, named in this desk's notes, which disagree as described. **No hobby-market size is printed, because no credible one exists.**

THE DEEP END · THE MACHINES

A Precision Matthews PM-1236T is US$6,999.99; the tooling costs half as much again

The forums' buy-once lathe, a benchtop mill and the metrology to use them land near US$14,000 — while a broken Monarch 10EE sells for US$5,000 and a remanufactured one lists at US$98,781.

The cheap tier gets one line, because this reader should skip it: the seven-by-twelve mini lathe at about US$1,045 and the mill-drill at US$729 exist to be outgrown, and are the hobby's most common regret.[1]

The quality entry point is **Precision Matthews**. Its ten-by-twenty-two lathes run **US$3,299 to US$3,999**; the forum's most-recommended buy-once machine is the twelve-by-thirty-six **PM-1236T at US$6,999.99**, with the PM-1340GT at US$7,999.99 above it. Mills follow the same shape: the PM-728VT benchtop from **US$3,699.99**, the PM-833TV at US$4,999. In Britain the equivalents are Warco's inverter machines — the WM250V with readout at **£2,995**, the WM16B mill at £2,095. For CNC: a Tormach xsTECH is US$4,535, a PCNC 440 US$8,995.[2]

Then the part nobody budgets for. A **Starrett nought-to-one-inch micrometer is US$349.99**; the budget equivalent on the same shelf is **US$34.95**. A dial test indicator reading to a ten-thousandth, US$399.99 against US$69.95. A Kurt DX6 vise is US$700, an eighty-one-piece gauge block set US$229.95.[3]

The community has said this for fourteen years and keeps saying it. One member in 2012 put his own five-year total above US$8,000. Another, in 2021: "you could easily spend as much as your entire budget on tooling for your lathe once you get it." A third, in 2017: "I wasted a lot of money on tooling that I thought I needed... Some has never been used and maybe never will."[4]

> ***"The machines were the cheapest part only a large one time expense but your tooling will far exceed the machine cost."***

At the top the sums turn strange. The **Monarch 10EE**, introduced in 1939, is the American grail. On one dealer listing this week a 1964 and a 1977 example are both offered at **US$5,000**. On the same site a 2025 remanufactured 10EE, from Monarch's own factory town in Sidney, Ohio, lists at **US$98,781**.[5]

$9,500

A LATHE, A TOOLING PACKAGE, A VISE, A MICROMETER, GAUGE BLOCKS AND A COLLET SET — BEFORE CUTTING ANYTHING, AND WITH NO MILL[3]

THE CHATTER · THE STANDING ARGUMENTS

Chinese import against old American iron. Settled position: a new Taiwanese machine beats a worn Chinese one and a tired American one, and costs more than either. One member: "I'd buy a new Taiwan mill or lathe from Matt before even considering a used machine." The counter, same thread: "these are Chinese machines, they're not the highest quality" — then a vise that split in half in a fortnight.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE PRICES WENT

The best-sourced tariff fact here comes not from a pundit but from the man who imports the machines, in his own sponsor forum in March 2025: **"With the original 4.2 to 8% before this all started, plus the 25% added in 2018, we have paid around 30-33%... Now, it is that, plus 10%, plus 10% now, we are basically at 50-53% total." This desk found no 2026 update and does not present it as today's rate.**[7]

SOURCES Every price here was read on 23 October 2026 from the vendor's own live storefront, four of them through the store's product data rather than its rendered page. 1 A US vendor's catalogue. 2 Precision Matthews' own lathe and mill collections; Warco's own catalogue; Tormach's own machines page — **where a table lower on that page gives different figures from the product grid; the grid is quoted and the discrepancy noted.** 3 One American retailer's own shelf, so budget and premium are like for like; the vise from an industrial distributor, as **the maker's own site is Cloudflare-blocked.** 4 Three dated posts on an American hobby forum: 31 August 2012, 15 January 2021 and 31 July 2017. 5 A used-machinery listing service, read 23 October, for both US$5,000 machines and the US$98,781 remanufactured one; a lathe-history archive for the 1939 date. 6 A thread running 2015 to 2022, read at source. 7 The importer's own post of 18 March 2025 in his sponsor forum. **Reddit's member counts were readable through a mirror, but no comment page was: every quotation across these three pages comes from a forum this desk could open, and none from Reddit.**

THE DEEP END · SHERLINE'S EXIT

Sherline suspended new orders on 19 October; Taig is the last one standing

The Vista, California firm said on 16 September it would stop manufacturing, and on 20 October that it was in talks to sell the intellectual property.

The biggest thing to happen to hobby machining this year happened six weeks ago and has barely been reported. **Sherline Products of Vista, California** — the benchtop precision maker every space-constrained hobbyist was told to buy — said on **16 September** that it would cease manufacturing. On **20 October** its co-owners posted that they are "in discussions with an American manufacturer regarding the potential purchase" of the intellectual property and remaining inventory, that **"no final agreement has been reached"**, and that they had agreed to suspend new orders "effective October 19, 2026."[1]

The stated reason is "significant changes in consumer purchasing habits". In the thread that followed, a moderator argues that buyers now take a cheaper mini lathe instead. The line to keep is blunter: **"The harsh reality appears to be that existing stock will run-out."**[1]

Three things changed this year. **The electronic leadscrew went mainstream**: Warco sells a line in which a stepper replaces the change-gear train, so you dial a thread pitch instead of swapping gears — the D210EL with readout at **£2,295**. **Carbide3D's Nomad 4**, listed 13 May at **US$5,400**, puts a 1.2-kilowatt spindle and ballscrews in an enclosed desktop box. And **Alibre** sells a perpetual parametric CAD licence at **US$199**, the honest answer to what replaced Fusion.[2]

The first ninety days cost nothing for thirty: read the beginners' boards and watch Blondihacks for structure. Then the entry pair, a PM-1236T and a PM-728VT: **US$10,700 of machines** and about **US$3,300** of tooling. Three projects, in order: soft jaws for your own chuck; a machinist's hammer, the first part needing both machines; and a steam engine from castings.[3]

A GLOSSARY FOR THE FIRST WEEK

Swarf the chips. **Tenths** ten-thousandths of an inch. **Tramming** squaring the mill head to its table. **Backlash** slop before the table moves. **Parting off** cutting the piece free, the most feared operation here.

THE CHATTER · MISTAKES, BLUNDERS & BOO BOOS

One forum keeps a board with that name — **224 threads, 3,200 messages** — and it reads as a liability register: "Wrong way fly cutter", "Almost burned my shop down and didn't even know it". The canonical first mistake is the chuck key left in the chuck; the second is parting off. A July thread gives the method — blade on centre height or a thousandth below, minimal stick-out, steady feed, because hesitating work-hardens the cut — then two members disagree on speed.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · IN SINGAPORE, HONESTLY, ALMOST NOBODY

Two constraints decide it, and neither is noise. **Floor loading:** a twelve-by-thirty-six lathe ships at 1,020 pounds and the fourteen-inch class well over a tonne, a point load no residential slab is specified for. **Power:** homes here are 230 volts single phase, and three-phase to a dwelling goes through a licensed electrical worker case by case. That leaves a Taig-sized inverter machine bolted to a steel bench in a landed house, **US$440 with a motor now that Sherline has gone**, or a rented B2 unit in Ubi. **No Singapore model engineering club surfaced in any search. That absence is the finding.**[5]

NEXT DESCENTS

Violin making (lutherie) — spruce, maple and three centuries of argument about varnish.

Archery (recurve, compound & traditional) — limbs, spine and the quietest arms race in sport.

Competitive barbecue — offset smokers and what a hand-built pit costs.

SOURCES 1 Sherline's own site, read 23 October 2026, for the 20 October notice and both quoted sentences; the Model Engineer forum thread "Sherline closing down", 16 September to 23 October, 21 posts across eight voices, for the announcement, the stated reason and every member quotation. 2 Warco's own catalogue for the electronic-leadscrew line; Carbide3D's own product page, listed 13 May 2026, for the Nomad 4; Alibre's own pricing page. **Autodesk's site returned 403, so the free personal licence is not asserted; and no hobby-price metal 3D printer was found, so none is claimed.** 3 Machine and tooling prices as on p16; the project sequence from the recurring first-build threads on two forums. 4 One forum's own board statistics and thread titles, read at source, with the parting-off thread of 27 July 2026 for the method and for both opposing replies. 5 Machine weights from the vendors' own specifications; the power position from a licensed-supply handbook, **presented as case-by-case because the utility's service page returned 404 and the housing board's renovation pages did the same.**

FITNESS · THE RING ON THE BENCH

NUS validated the Oura ring against actigraphy on 41 adults aged twenty-six

Sleep Health published the comparison on 9 October: agreement of 0.67 to 0.98 across rest-activity metrics. Three of the six authors sit in the Oura–NUS Joint Lab, and a mid-forties reader is twenty years older than the sample.

The Centre for Sleep and Cognition at the National University of Singapore published a head-to-head comparison in *Sleep Health* on 9 October: **41 healthy adults, mean age 26.3, 27 of them women**, wearing an Oura ring and an Actiwatch AW2 concurrently for fourteen days, a mean of 10.6 valid overlapping days each.[1]

The metrics are the non-parametric rest-activity ones — interdaily stability, intradaily variability, relative amplitude, and the timing of the least-active five hours and most-active ten. Agreement was **moderate to excellent, with intraclass coefficients from 0.67 to 0.98** and Spearman correlations from 0.71 to 0.98, holding across three separate processing pipelines. The ring read interdaily stability slightly higher and intradaily variability slightly lower than the research-grade watch.[1]

Two things to say plainly before anyone generalises. The mean age is 26.3, so the sample contains nobody of this reader's age and nothing about how these metrics behave on a fifty-year-old wrist. And **three of the six authors, including the senior author, are affiliated with the "Oura–NUS Joint Lab, Oura Pte Ltd, Singapore"**. No comparable Whoop validation appeared in the window — the nearest was a single-case study of one elite junior swimmer.[1]

Two findings with something to do on Monday. First, the lifting day. Significant for ten per cent against thirty and ten against twenty; not significant for twenty against forty.[2]

In practice: stop the set when bar speed has dropped about a tenth from your best rep, rather than grinding on to a twenty or thirty per cent loss. The authors apply their own brake, and it should be printed with the finding: lower velocity loss "may therefore be considered as one potential option… **rather than a universally superior prescription**", on low-to-moderate certainty, in trained athletes rather than general-population lifters.[2]

Second, sleep, where the useful result is a ceiling. Exercise cut both the Pittsburgh and the Insomnia Severity scores and did **nothing** for daytime sleepiness on the Epworth scale: it improves how you sleep, not how awake you feel.[3]

539

MET-MINUTES A WEEK — THE DOSE WITH THE LARGEST PREDICTED EFFECT ON SLEEP QUALITY. THE CURVE IS AN INVERTED U; MORE WAS WORSE

THE CHATTER · ATTIA AGAINST THE SHINY THING

The best piece of longevity writing in the window is Peter Attia arguing himself out of a drug class. His conclusion: "the most important intervention for building strong muscles will remain resistance training."[4]

THE SCEPTIC · FIVE TRIALS, ONE HUNDRED AND TWENTY PEOPLE

Time-restricted feeding plus resistance training has an app economy, a supplement economy and a podcast economy behind it. General guidance, not medical advice.[5]

SOURCES 1 Qin S, Jouvencel A, Soon CS, Shaif N, Ong JL, Chee MWL, "Comparison of rest-activity rhythm metrics derived from Oura ring and actiwatch devices", *Sleep Health*, online 9 October 2026, doi:10.1016/j.sleh.2026.09.011, read at source. Sample size, mean age, wear period, the coefficient ranges and the three pipelines are the paper's own; **the Oura–NUS Joint Lab affiliation is stated in the paper's own author list.** 2 Zhang J et al., *Frontiers in Physiology* 2026;17:1893020, 6 October 2026, doi:10.3389/fphys.2026.1893020, PROSPERO CRD420261396083, read at source. The effect size, interval, heterogeneity, the significant and non-significant comparisons and the quoted caveat are the authors'. 3 Wang T, Ma Z, Zhu B, Tang Y, *Journal of Exercise Science & Fitness* 2026;24(4):200526, epub 1 October 2026, doi:10.1016/j.jesf.2026.200526, read at source. The three standardised mean differences, the null Epworth result and the 539 MET-minute inverted-U dose are the paper's; the authors describe the evidence as low-to-moderate certainty and say exercise "may reduce". 4 Peter Attia, "Myostatin inhibitors and the paradox of larger but weaker muscles", 3 October 2026, read at source, with Michael Rae and Lauren Fritsch; every trial figure quoted is as he reports it there, **and the enobosarm result he also lists is company-reported and is not printed here.** 5 Verdi AMOH et al., *Anais da Academia Brasileira de Ciências* 2026;98(3):e20240672, 9 October 2026, doi:10.1590/0001-3765202620240672, PROSPERO CRD42023423274, read at source. **No Huberman, Rhonda Patrick or Reddit material appears on this page: nothing from either was published in the window that this desk could read, and Reddit refused the sandbox for the tenth issue running.** This page is general guidance, not medical advice.

THE TRAVEL DESK · JAPAN'S TAX-FREE SWITCH

Tax-free shopping in Japan ends on 1 November; you will claim at the airport

Purchases up to 31 October follow the old National Tax Agency rules. From Sunday week the minimum spend is ¥5,000 regardless of goods type, and the sealed-bag rule and the ¥500,000 daily cap both go.

From **1 November 2026** Japan replaces point-of-sale tax exemption with a refund claimed on departure: you pay the ten per cent at the till and get it back afterwards. Anything bought **up to and including 31 October** is handled the old way, which makes next weekend the hinge for anyone in the country.[1]

Three rules loosen. The minimum spend becomes **¥5,000 regardless of goods type** — the consumables category disappears, and with it the sealed-packaging rule that has had tourists carrying taped bags of cosmetics for a decade. The ¥500,000 daily cap goes. Purchases over a million yen still need product registration.[1]

The mechanics are where trips go wrong. You scan your passport at a tax-free terminal in the public area, **before checking your bags** — green means done, red means presenting the goods to Customs, which a checked bag makes impossible. Departure must be within 90 days, and the shop or its refund operator pays, not Customs: one to two weeks by card, two to four by transfer. **If any single listed item is missing at the check, the exemption on all of them is invalidated.**[1]

Two route changes land in the same week, and one has an unreported casualty. Singapore Airlines begins **Singapore–Barcelona–Madrid on Monday 26 October**: SQ388 leaves at 23:30 and reaches Madrid at 08:50, its fifteenth European destination and first since 2004. What goes is the twice-weekly Barcelona non-stop and, on **27 October, the Singapore–Milan–Barcelona service**, which takes Milan off the SIA map altogether.[2]

And on **Wednesday 28 October** Air New Zealand returns to Singapore–Christchurch non-stop for the first time in six and a half years: NZ67 at 00:40 arriving 15:35, Mondays, Wednesdays and Fridays, on a 787-9 with four Business Premier Luxe seats at the front, **S$680 one way** above Business Premier. With Singapore Airlines running up to twelve a week, that is **fifteen weekly non-stops to the South Island** through the ski and dark-sky season.[3]

Feb 2027

WHEN PASSENGER SERVICE ON THE JOHOR BAHRU–WOODLANDS RAIL LINK IS NOW EXPECTED TO BEGIN — NOT END-2026

IN BRIEF

The RTS Link has a date at last, and it is not this year. RTS Operations said on 2 October that passenger service is expected to start in **February 2027**, with tests and trial runs targeted for completion by 31 December. **Fares and operating hours are still unannounced.**[4]

Singapore Airlines showed next-generation KrisWorld on 22 October; the cabins come next month. Forty-one A350s retrofit from the first quarter of 2027: 32-inch 4K in First, 22-inch OLED in Business, 2,500-plus titles against about 1,900. **The new long-haul First and Business cabins are unveiled in Singapore in November.**[5]

First Class is going back into Gatwick. From 1 October 2027 a four-class 777-300ER replaces the A350 on SQ312/309, adding four First suites and taking Gatwick to daily.[6]

Changi's early check-in was reshuffled on 10 October: 42 airlines, up to 48 hours ahead. Singapore Airlines passengers can check in two days early at T2 from 04:30 and T3 from 05:00, though immigration access is capped at 24 hours. **Jewel's desks are down to 19 airlines.**[7]

The Amex KrisFlyer cashback deal halves and gets easier. The current S$150 for S$12,000 of spend plus an S$800 SIA ticket closes **18 November**; from the 19th it is S$100 for S$6,000 plus a S$400 ticket — a return improving from 1.25 to 1.67 per cent.[8]

Deltas: the Japan Rail Pass rose on 1 October, seven-day ordinary to **¥53,000**, though **the pass's own site would not serve its price page**. Scoot's Okinawa service, sometimes reported as launching next month, **began in December 2025**.[9]

SOURCES 1 The National Tax Agency's guidance as summarised by a Japan travel title, read at source 24 October, for the date, the ¥5,000 threshold, the abolished consumables category, the sealed-packaging rule and daily cap, the terminal mechanics, the refund timings and the all-items invalidation. **The agency's own page could not be reached directly.** 2 Singapore Airlines' press release as carried by an aviation-industry service, plus a Singapore miles title, both read 24 October. **The two disagree on frequency; the day-pattern schedule supports five weekly, which is what is printed. The airline's own newsroom URL 404'd.** 3 A Singapore aviation title, read at source, for the flight numbers, days, aircraft, cabin counts and the Luxe supplement. 4 Bernama, 2 October 2026, quoting RTS Operations. 5 A Singapore aviation title, 22 October 2026. 6 The same title, 11 October 2026, for the aircraft swap and suite count. 7 The same title, 10 October 2026. 8 The same title, 19 October. 9 AeroRoutes, 20 August 2026, for the Naha frequency and the December 2025 launch; Kyodo for the rail-pass rise. **No disruption item appears on this page: a search for October 2026 strikes, closures and advisories returned nothing newer than August.**

THE TRAVEL DESK · THE PALAWAN REROUTE

Cebu Pacific moved El Nido's flights from Manila to Clark in March

AirSWIFT stopped existing as an operating brand on 1 July; Cebgo now flies every one of its routes under the code DG. The guidebooks still say fly Manila, and a reader who does faces a ten-hour door-to-door day.

Cebu Pacific moved **all** of its turboprop operations out of Manila's Ninoy Aquino International Airport to Clark on **29 March 2026**, under a resolution of the Manila Slot Coordination Committee. Clark is about 80 kilometres north-west of the capital. Schedules and times were kept.[1]

The consequence for anyone planning the trip on page 21 is blunt. **There are no El Nido flights from Manila's main airport.** Lio airport, at El Nido, is now served from Clark, Cebu, Caticlan and Coron only. One who did it in April put the day at about ten hours door to door and said he would next time route through Cebu instead.[2]

The routing that works from Singapore is the one locals give arriving international passengers: **Singapore to Cebu, then Cebu to Lio.** Singapore–Cebu is nonstop on three carriers at roughly twenty weekly departures and three hours forty, and the Cebu–El Nido sector opened on 26 October 2025 — it has its first anniversary this Monday. The alternative worth keeping is Manila to Busuanga on Philippine Airlines, which still flies it, with the ferry or a forty-minute hop onward.[3]

Build a buffer day before any international connection out of Palawan. Coron in particular has a reputation for cancellations, and the network now runs through two hubs where it used to run through one.

49.78

SINGAPORE DOLLARS TO THE PESO ON 23 OCTOBER — THE STRONGEST THE SGD HAS BEEN AGAINST THE PHP ALL YEAR, UP 8.8 PER CENT SINCE JANUARY

SNOW, AND WHERE TO SLEEP IN IT

Niseko Village's eight-person gondola opens in December, doubling base uplift, with VIP and glass-floor cabins; stage one runs base to mid-mountain this winter and the summit section follows in 2027.[4]

Moxy Niseko Village opened on 3 September — 310 rooms over five storeys beside the Niseko Village gondola, Marriott's first Moxy in Hokkaido. Also pipelined for December: **Hotel101-Niseko**, 482 rooms, which would become the largest hotel in Hirafu, and **The Alps Hotel Hakuba**, ski-in to Hakuba Norikura. Hoshinoya's 62-room Hirafu lodge is listed for completion this year with **no confirmed opening date**.[4]

THE CHATTER · THE CURRENCY IS DOING THE ARGUING

The loudest complaint in Philippine travel forums this year is value for money, and it is louder from Filipinos than from foreigners. The complaint is real and it is not the reader's complaint (p14).[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THIS DESK COULD NOT STAND UP

Three things a travel page would normally assert and this one will not. And the Japan Rail Pass question is genuinely open: the seven-day ordinary pass rose to ¥53,000 on 1 October, but reporting disagrees about whether the official online channel held the old price while agents charged the new one — **and the pass's own site served us navigation instead of a price page on two attempts, with the www host failing DNS outright.** Nobody should book on our arithmetic there.[6]

SOURCES 1 Philippine business and aviation reporting of 16 June 2026 and an aviation-analysis service, both read at source, for the Cebgo takeover, the code change and the aircraft transfers; a Philippine ports-and-logistics title for the 29 March Clark move and the slot-committee resolution. 2 A Philippine travel guide's airport page, checked by its author on 10 August 2026, for the Lio route map and the Clark transfer; the ten-hour account is a named traveller's own report of an April 2026 journey, read at source. 3 A flight-schedule aggregator updated 29 June 2026 for the Singapore–Cebu frequency and block time; the Cebu–El Nido opening date from the same guide. Philippine Airlines' own route page for Manila–Busuanga. 4 An Australian travel-trade report of 18 August 2026 for the gondola and the hotel pipeline; **Hoshinoya's Hirafu lodge has no confirmed opening date and none is invented here.** 5 Forum sentiment read at source from Reddit's Atom feeds, which still serve when the web interface does not — **the normal site, three alternative front-ends and an RSS relay all refused this sandbox, and every quotation here was read from a feed on 24 October rather than recalled.** The exchange rates are European Central Bank reference rates via a public API, read 23 October. 6 Pre-closure reporting on Jetstar Asia and the absence of anything later; Changi's own T5 timeline; Kyodo on the rail-pass rise. **japanrailpass.net returned navigation only on two attempts and its www host failed DNS, so the online-versus-agent question is left open rather than resolved by inference.**

THE GRAND TOUR · PALAWAN

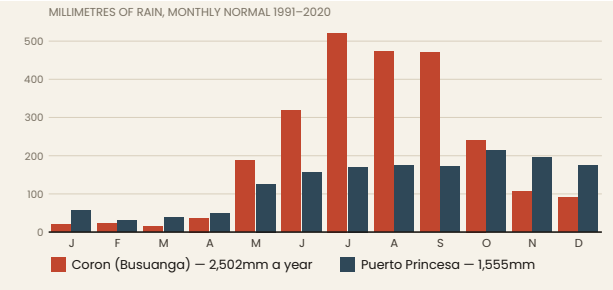
Coron takes 521 millimetres of rain in July; Puerto Princesa's wettest month is October

PAGASA's 1991–2020 normals record two climates inside one province, and the wrong one is the one travellers read. El Nido behaves like Coron, which moves the window to February and March.

The first thing to know about Palawan is that it does not have a climate; it has at least two, and the one most travellers check is the wrong one. PAGASA publishes 1991–2020 normals at both official stations, and they are not close. **Coron, on Busuanga, takes 2,502 millimetres a year. Puerto Princesa, 350 kilometres south, takes 1,555.**[1]

The shape matters more than the total. Coron's year is violently seasonal: **March brings 15.4 millimetres across three rainy days, and July alone brings 521.5 millimetres over 21** — more than a third of Puerto Princesa's entire annual rainfall, in one month. Puerto Princesa has no dry season: it rains in every month, and **its wettest is October**.[1]

El Nido has no PAGASA station. It sits at the north-west tip of the mainland and behaves far more like Coron than like Puerto Princesa — an inference from geography and the wind regime, not a measured record. **We deep-dived Palawan four weeks ago, at No. 114, off Puerto Princesa alone, and put the window in March and April. The second station moves it, and that correction is why we are back early.**[1]



Two stations, one province. Monthly rainfall normals 1991–2020, from PAGASA's own PDFs, read locally. A *Meridian* original.[1]

So the window is narrower and earlier than the brochures' December-to-April. **February and March are the sweet spot**; January is meteorologically similar and priced for the holidays. July, August and September take 1,464 millimetres across 60 rainy days between them.[1]

Late October — now — is a genuine shoulder: Coron's normal is 241 millimetres across 14 days, down from September's 470 but still seven times March. Travellers posting from El Nido this week put it accurately: "Usually sunny from morning to noon. Then it rains."[2]

Glassy water is a function of wind, not rain: Bacuit Bay opens to the north-east, so the monsoon builds chop on exposed crossings under a clear sky while the enclosed lagoons stay flat. Tour C is the first cancelled. **Build a spare day into any itinerary containing it.**[3]

903,166

VISITORS TO EL NIDO IN 2019, AGAINST 76,815 IN 2008 — AND A RESIDENT POPULATION OF ABOUT 51,367

THE CHATTER · PALAWAN IS BOAT COUNTRY

The message that breaks the most trips is that you cannot do this place independently. A couple arrived in January wanting what they had done in Thailand — scooter, beach, snorkel — and the replies were unanimous. **"The geography of Coron doesn't lend itself to solo exploration… Palawan is the most beautiful tropical island setting I've been to on Earth,"** wrote one. Another: "You are in an archipelago now."[2]

THE SCEPTIC · LOW IS NOT ZERO, AND NOBODY PUBLISHES THE CAPS

Palawan sits south and west of the main typhoon track, in a country PAGASA says takes about twenty cyclones a year, eight or nine landfalling, nearly seventy per cent between July and October. Low is not zero. And the practical consequence survives all of it: **the first boat out sees a different lagoon from the fourth.**[4]

SOURCES 1 PAGASA, Climatology and Agrometeorology Division, "Climatological Normals" 1991–2020, Coron and Puerto Princesa stations, downloaded as PDFs from the agency's own file server and text-extracted locally on 24 October 2026. Every rainfall, rainy-day, temperature and wind figure here and in the figure comes from those two documents. **El Nido has no station; the comparison to Coron is this desk's inference from geography and the monsoon regime, and is labelled as such. No sea-temperature figure is printed: the only monthly series found is forward-dated and internally inconsistent.** The No. 114 comparison is to this magazine's own archived edition of 26 September 2026. 2 Traveller accounts read from Reddit's Atom feeds on 24 October — **the only route that served this sandbox; quotations are read, not recalled.** The weather posts are dated 18–20 October 2026, the boat-country thread 17 January 2026. 3 A Philippine travel guide whose author checked the tour rules on 22 August 2026. 4 PAGASA's own tropical-cyclone page for the annual counts; the Asian Development Bank's 2022 carrying-capacity brief for the modelled figures. **TripAdvisor and FlyerTalk both returned 403, so no forum content from either appears on these pages.**

THE GRAND TOUR · CORON AND EL NIDO

Coron is quieter than in a decade; El Nido's town water is still polluted

El Nido's sewage plant runs at half capacity and 3.3 per cent of town households were connected in January 2025, while the lagoons themselves met standards throughout.

Where to sleep decides the trip. **El Nido town** is walkable to the piers and the operators, and the only sensible base for a first-timer without transport. It is also loud, and it has a documented water problem: a sewage plant opened in December 2022 runs at about half capacity, and in January 2025 **only 3.3 per cent of town households were connected**. Coastal water in front of the town exceeded the recreational faecal-coliform limit from 2019 to 2023. **The tour sites met standards throughout**: the problem is the beach.[1]

Travellers raise it unprompted: "be careful with the water there, turns out it is badly polluted and I get sick every time I come home." Filipino commenters advise bottled water even for brushing teeth. **Corong-Corong**, just south, is the compromise, and where the vans from Puerto Princesa terminate; **Lio Beach** is immaculate and detached.[2]

Coron town is cheaper, more relaxed and the dive base, and has essentially no beach — "straight up boring if you dont do the tours", as one traveller puts it. What it has instead is the wrecks. On **24 September 1944** the US Third Fleet caught a Japanese supply fleet in Coron Bay with 96 Hellcats flown from about 340 miles away, the longest-range carrier strike of the war. The **Okikawa Maru** is 160 metres, upright, main deck at 10 to 16; the **Irako** stands at 34 to 43.[3]

Do not let anyone sell that to you as the best wreck diving in Asia. No specialist title this desk read makes the comparison, and visibility complicates it: **six to nine metres on average**. The honest claim is better — the most accessible concentration of large intact wrecks in Asia, shallow enough for a recreational diver.[3]

Of the two lakes, **Kayangan** is the most photographed thing in the Calamianes and a queue after nine; **Barracuda Lake** is a dive rather than a swim, through a thermocline so sharp you pass into water in the high thirties within a metre. What makes a Palawan trip more than a beach holiday is the crossing: a traveller who went with **Tao Philippines** in April paid **US$750 for the five-day Original.**[4]

WHAT IT ACTUALLY COSTS

ITEM	PHP	≈ SGD
Joiner tour A or D	1,200–1,500	24–30
Two-tank wreck dive	3,500–5,500	70–110
Tao Original, 5 days, pp	44,152	887
Island resort, per night	34,400–60,800	691–1,221

Converted at 49.78 pesos to the Singapore dollar. **A twelve-year-old is charged as an extra adult at El Nido Resorts, 18,000 to 20,000 pesos.**[5]

THE CHATTER · THE OVERTOURISM STORY HAS PARTLY REVERSED

A traveller writing from Coron in December, in what should be peak season: **"the amount of tourists now are way below average than it usually is compared for the last 10 years." Coron delivers the uncrowded version of what El Nido sells crowded.**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · FOUR THINGS THE GUIDES GET WRONG

One. "Big Lagoon is kayak-only" is one operator's practice, not a rule: swimming the entrance channel in a life vest is allowed, and the kayak is 300 to 400 pesos *per two-seater*. **Two. Apulit Island Resort is listed by booking platforms as closed to 31 December 2026**, so every "four island properties" line in circulation is wrong, though El Nido Resorts' own site returned 403. **Three.** A ten-kilometre drone restriction around Lio airport covers most of Bacuit Bay. **Four.** The US CDC lists **Palawan as a malaria transmission area**; risk in the tourist strip is low, but a doctor will go by the province listing.[6]

SOURCES 1 A Philippine travel guide citing municipal and Environmental Management Bureau data, read at source, for the plant's capacity, the 3.3 per cent connection rate, the 2019–2023 coliform record and the finding that the tour sites met standards. 2 Traveller accounts read from Reddit's Atom feeds on 24 October — **the only route that served this sandbox; every quotation was read, none recalled**. Dates run from November 2025 to April 2026. 3 Divernet's account of the 1944 strike and of each wreck, read at source, for the aircraft numbers, the depths and the visibility; the "best in Asia" claim appears in **no specialist source read for this page**. 4 A named traveller's April 2026 account, read at source, for the US$750 price; **Tao publishes no prices on its own site, and its booking calendar showed no availability from October to March — which may be a default filter, not a closure**. 5 Joiner and dive prices from a Philippine travel guide checked in August 2026; **resort nightlies are 2025 promotional figures, because elnidoresorts.com returned 403 twice and no 2026 rate card was obtained. Amanpulo publishes no rate and none is invented.** Conversions at European Central Bank reference rates, 23 October. 6 The US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's Philippines destination page, read at source, for the malaria listing; the lagoon and drone points from the guide at note 5; the Apulit closure from three booking platforms.

THE DIARY · BEFORE THE YEAR TURNS

ART SG's two-for-one tickets expire on 24 November; sumo opens 5 December

BABYMONSTER's two Indoor Stadium nights on 28 and 29 November are the only big show with a published price ladder, S$168 to S$358. Nothing else checked carries a sold-out flag.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

20–29 Nov — **Kalaa Utsavam · Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE — THEATRES ON THE BAY · SHOW PRICES NOT PUBLISHED ON THE FESTIVAL PAGE

28–29 Nov — ★ **BABYMONSTER · CHOOM World Tour**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · 6PM · S$168–358 EXCL. FEES · VIP ADDS SOUNDCHECK AND PHOTOCARDS

21–24 Jan — ★ **ART SG 2027**
MARINA BAY SANDS EXPO · VERNISSAGE 21ST · **EARLY-BIRD TWO-FOR-ONE ENDS 24 NOV, 23:59** · UNDER-16S FREE

15–31 Jan — **Light to Night Singapore 2027**
NATIONAL GALLERY AND THE CIVIC DISTRICT · LARGELY FREE · TICKETING NOT YET DETAILED

30–31 Jan — **HSBC SVNS Singapore**
NOT YET ON SALE · THE SERIES SELLS ONLY DUBAI, CAPE TOWN, PERTH AND NEW YORK · VENUE UNNAMED ON THE OFFICIAL PAGE

12 FEB — **Maroon 5 · Asia 2027**
NATIONAL STADIUM · 8PM · GENERAL SALE LISTED; NO PRICES PUBLISHED

From Feb — **Moulin Rouge! The Musical**
SANDS THEATRE · SOUTH-EAST ASIAN PREMIERE · BOOKING LIVE · **CLOSING DATE UNCONFIRMED AT SOURCE**

13–18 Apr — ★ **Bruno Mars · The Romantic Tour**
NATIONAL STADIUM · FOUR NIGHTS, 8PM · ANDERSON .PAAK AS DJ PEE .WEE · NO PRICES ON THE PROMOTER PAGE

Apr 2027 — **Attack on Titan: The Musical**
SANDS THEATRE · SOUTH-EAST ASIAN PREMIERE · MONTH ONLY AT SOURCE; ON-SALE NOT STATED

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

30 Oct–11 Jan — **Haruichi Furudate · HAIKYU!! Challengers**
MORI ARTS CENTER GALLERY, ROPPONGI HILLS, TOKYO · ADMISSION NOT PUBLISHED

29–31 Dec — **Comic Market 109**
TOKYO BIG SIGHT · CIRCLE APPLICATIONS OUT; **ATTENDEE WRISTBANDS NOT YET ON SALE** · IGNORE THE ENGLISH INDEX, IT IS STALE

10–24 Jan — ★ **Grand Sumo · Hatsu Basho**
RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · FIFTEEN DAYS · **ADVANCE SALES OPEN SAT 5 DEC** · JANUARY BANDS NOT YET PUBLISHED

15–17 Jan — **Tokyo Auto Salon 2027**
MAKUHARI MESSE, CHIBA · ON-SALE AND PRICES NOT YET PUBLISHED · THE ORGANISER SAYS JANUARY, NOT FEBRUARY

25–27 Mar — **Art Basel Hong Kong 2027**
HONG KONG · VENUE NOT NAMED ON THE ORGANISER PAGE · TICKETS NOT YET ON SALE

9–11 Apr — ★ **Hong Kong Sevens 2027**
KAI TAK STADIUM · EASTER WEEKEND · **"TICKETING DETAILS TO FOLLOW"** · SIGN-UP LIST OPEN

PLANNING NOTES

One hard price cliff and one single-Saturday on-sale. ART SG's two-for-one early bird dies at **23:59 on 24 November** — two adults for S$40 on the Friday against S$80 later — and under-16s enter free with a ticketed adult, which makes it a good first art fair for a twelve-year-old.[1]

THE SCEPTIC · ONE CALL MARKED, AND ONE CAVEAT

This desk said Kenshi Yonezu's 29 January show would sell out on its 22 October general-sale day; it has not, and a second night has since appeared. One caveat covering this page: **Ticketmaster Singapore and the stadium precinct both blocked automated checks, so "on sale" here means the promoter's page still offers it, not a live inventory read. Post Malone stays barred**, as since No. 85.[2]

SOURCES 1 Every row above was verified against a promoter, venue or organiser page rather than an aggregator, read on 23 October 2026: the fair's own site and ticket page for ART SG; the promoter's own event pages for BABYMONSTER, Bruno Mars, Maroon 5 and Moulin Rouge; the Esplanade's festivals page; the National Gallery's own site; the series organiser's tickets page for both Sevens; the official sumo portal for the Hatsu Basho dates and the 5 December on-sale; Comiket's own site; the Tokyo Auto Salon organiser's 2027 page; the Mori Arts Center Gallery; and Art Basel's own Hong Kong page. **Where a venue or price is not named on the organiser's own page, this desk says so in the row rather than filling it from a listings site.** *Moulin Rouge*'s reported 4 April closing date appears only in press, so only the opening month is printed. 2 Live Nation Singapore's own Singapore and global artist pages, read 23 October, for the two Kenshi Yonezu dates and beabadoobee's still-open sale. **ticketmaster.sg returned 403 on every path and the stadium precinct the same; SISTIC loads but reports zero results for everything.** Barred events are checked against this magazine's own events ledger before any row is printed.

THE TABLE · OCTOBER'S OPENINGS

Sodeng Jeju caps its fourteen-day-aged black pork at twenty servings a day

The Bugis room opened on 6 October with one substantial review to its name. Tofu G's new toppings bar costs S$2 flat; a Boat Quay dive bar pours until 3am seven nights and nobody has reviewed it at all.

Sodeng Jeju is the strongest thing to open in Singapore this month and the easiest to explain: Korean vintage barbecue with the whole menu built around Jeju Island rather than generic grill, from a group already running Telok Ayer and Amoy Street outlets. The black pork and the banchan come from Jeju. Around it: Jeju pork noodle soup at S$19, a squid-and-pork *osam-duruchigi* platter at S$38, abalone liver pot rice at S$16.[1]

On the buzz, be careful. One substantial review exists — a Singapore lifestyle title on 5 October, whose verdict is flatly affirmative: "Yes, Sodeng Jeju is worth visiting." It was published the day before the restaurant was a week old. There is no queue reporting and no waitlist; reservations are merely recommended. Book dinner and ask them to hold the aged belly; it is the only reason to choose this over the group's other two rooms.[1]

Tofu G is the divisive one, and the division is the interesting part. The brand — Korean tofu gelato, high-protein and low-fat, made with Korean soybeans in hanok-styled rooms — already had Amoy Street, Mandarin Gallery and Takashimaya counters. Chodang Sweet Corn is Waterway Point only; pomegranate is Suntec only.[2]

Time Out's tasting piece says the viral gelato is "worth all the hype" and calls the price "a tad pricey but entirely worth the dollar". Sources conflict on whether the vegan options are dairy-free, so this desk makes no dietary claim.[2]

A Bar Called Bar gets printed as the discovery it is rather than a verdict. One listing-level write-up exists and nothing else: **no review, no social chatter, no founders or chef named anywhere this desk could reach.** Too new to call, and said plainly.[3]

Bonsoir at Ma Cuisine is not a new room, and that is the point of printing it. A late-night wine bar in a restaurant that already exists is a cheaper, lower-risk thing to launch than a new lease, and in an autumn this thin on genuinely new rooms it is worth noticing that this is the form the new openings are taking.[4]

BUGIS · SUNTEC & PUNGGOL · BOAT QUAY · CRAIG ROAD · TOO NEW TO CALL ×2

THE CHATTER · WHAT COULD NOT BE READ

Four venues and **not one community read**, which is worth stating rather than disguising. What survives is published review text from the titles that do serve a reader — one for Sodeng Jeju, two opposed ones for Tofu G, a listing for the bar and nothing for the cafe — and that distribution is itself the honest picture of how thin October's class is.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THE BARRED LIST HAS EATEN THE HIGH END

There is no fine-dining room on this page, and the reason is structural rather than editorial. When a rotation rule starts consuming an entire category, that is information about how few genuinely new high-end rooms Singapore opened this autumn, not a gap in the page.[5]

SOURCES 1 A Singapore lifestyle title's review of 5 October 2026, read at source, for the concept, the Jeju sourcing, the twenty-serving cap, the quoted verdict and every price; the opening date and address from the same. 2 A Singapore news site's report of 22 September 2026 for the two new outlets, the toppings bar, the S$8 and S$2 prices and the outlet-specific flavours; Honeycombers' full review of 11 August 2026, read at source, for the dissenting verdict. **The Time Out line is quoted through a search index because that site refuses this sandbox (405 to a fetch, 403 to a browser request), and is flagged as second-hand.** 3 Honeycombers' new-bars round-up, read at source, for the address, the former tenant, the hours and the prices. **A dedicated search returned no review and no social chatter; no founder, operator or chef is named in any reachable source.** 4 Honeycombers' new-bars round-up, read at source, for the address, the Friday and Saturday hours, the popcorn and the croque monsieur price. **No chef, operator or opening date beyond the month is named in any reachable source.** 5 **Burpple returned 403, Instagram 429, Time Out 405 and 403, and Reddit refused every route — no community read was obtainable for any venue on this page.** The barred-list finding comes from reading the September and October opening round-ups of nine Singapore food titles plus a running tracker at source, and checking every name against this magazine's own Table ledger.

THE UNDERCURRENT · CHINA'S POWER RETAILERS

Nine state-owned Guangxi power retailers warned the regional government of mass bankruptcies

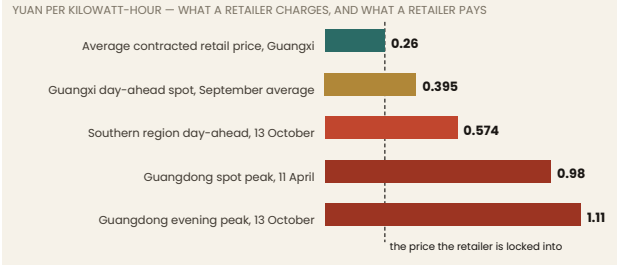
The petition went in on 30 September from subsidiaries holding about 70 per cent of the regional market. The trade's phrase for what is happening is 批零倒挂 — wholesale and retail hanging upside down — and Guangxi's retailers expect to lose more than five billion yuan this year.

On 30 September 2026 nine companies filed a document with the government of the Guangxi Zhuang Autonomous Region, titled, in the flat idiom of Chinese administrative petitions, a request for emergency measures to prevent systemic risk in the Guangxi electricity market. The nine are not insurgents: they are licensed electricity retailers, several of them subsidiaries of central state-owned enterprises. The letter warned of bankruptcies in the fourth quarter.[1]

The trade already had a phrase for the condition. **批零倒挂**, *pī líng dào guà*: wholesale and retail hanging upside down, the wholesale price having risen above the retail one. The vernacular version is better still — **「卖一度电，亏一度电」**, sell a kilowatt-hour, lose a kilowatt-hour.[2]

To see why nine state-owned enterprises are asking a provincial government for help, you need the layer they occupy. Between the generators and the factories sits a layer the 2025 reform invented: licensed retailers, more than 5,000 registered and about 3,000 active, which sign fixed-price annual contracts with industrial users and buy their power wholesale. In 2025 they handled roughly **four trillion kilowatt-hours** — about sixty per cent of all market-traded electricity in China.[3]

Then 2026 happened. Fuel costs rose after the Gulf disruption in February; hydro was weak; industrial load recovered. Wholesale prices went up and the retail contracts, written at 2025's deflationary prices, did not. In Guangxi the September day-ahead spot averaged **0.395 yuan a kilowatt-hour against an average contracted retail price of about 0.260**. Every unit sold under those contracts lost money, and the maximum loss reached **0.373 yuan on a single kilowatt-hour**.[4]



Each bar is a wholesale price a retailer had to pay; the dashed line is the retail price it had already promised. Figures as reported in Chinese business press, September and October 2026. A *Meridian* original.[4]

The arithmetic in the aggregate: **Guangxi's retailers lost more than two billion yuan in the first eight months of 2026, expected to lose over one billion in September alone, and more than five billion — about US$747m — across the year.** Individual firms lost over 130 million yuan in a single month. In the first quarter, 146 of them posted combined revenue of *minus* 645 million yuan: an average loss of 4.42 million yuan each.[4]

Guangxi is the extreme case and the reason is positioning, not bad luck. Its retailers bought about **half their volume on the spot market**, far more than elsewhere, and some had cut their medium- and long-term contract cover to thirty per cent. Guangdong's mix is roughly ninety per cent long-term. In a flat market that difference is a few basis points of margin. In this one it is solvency.[5]

0.373

YUAN — THE LARGEST LOSS A GUANGXI RETAILER TOOK ON A SINGLE KILOWATT-HOUR SOLD UNDER CONTRACT

SOURCES 1 The 30 September petition, as reported by two Chinese business outlets in the week of 9–10 October 2026 and read at source in the original; the nine signatories are named in that reporting and their parent groups are a matter of public record. 2 The two phrases are the trade's own and appear throughout the Chinese coverage cited here; the romanisation and literal translation are this desk's. 3 A Chinese business daily's 10 October account of the market structure, read at source, for the retailer counts, the four-trillion-kilowatt-hour volume and the sixty-per-cent share; Document No. 136 is the 2025 reform that put renewables on market pricing. 4 The same outlet for the Guangxi September spot average and the contracted retail price; an English-language Chinese financial service, 9 October 2026, for the loss totals, the single-firm figure and the 0.373-yuan maximum; a mainland financial portal, 14 May 2026, for the first-quarter revenue of 146 retailers. The Guangdong spot figures in the figure are from a Chinese technology and business title's October analysis and a financial magazine's cover story of 19 October, both read at source. **Dollar conversions are as published by the English-language service.** 5 The same October analysis for the spot-exposure split between the two provinces.

Guangdong is the control group, and it is the one that should frighten anyone who thinks this is a Guangxi problem. In 2025, **396 of 412 retailers there were profitable** — ninety-six per cent. In the first half of 2026, **298 of 500 were loss-making**: 59.6 per cent. The province with the conservative hedging book, ninety per cent long-term, flipped from almost universal profit to majority loss in six months.[1]

What flipped it was volatility rather than level. On 13 October the southern region's day-ahead average reached **0.5736 yuan a kilowatt-hour, up 19.8 per cent in a single day**, and the evening peak touched **1.11 yuan — nearly three times the average long-term contract price**. October's centralised trading composite came out at 0.4759, up 12.7 per cent on the month. Back in April the Guangdong spot had already hit 0.98 against a month-average contract price of 0.37, more than 160 per cent above it. A retailer hedged ninety per cent long and ten per cent spot can still be destroyed by the ten, if the ten triples.[1]

The exits are the clearest measure of what the reform has already done to the layer it created. **More than 3,200 retailers were cancelled or forced out in 2025 — about a third of the sector — and more than 400 more in the first seven months of 2026.** That is not a market correcting at the margin. That is an entire licensed intermediary class being liquidated two years after it was licensed.[2]

In 2025, ninety-six per cent of Guangdong's retailers made money. Six months later, sixty per cent were losing it.

Behind the insolvencies sits a second, uglier problem that the Chinese press has started naming. Guangdong's retailers competed for industrial customers by writing **返利** — rebate agreements — outside the registered contract. More than **ten billion yuan of those side agreements are now in dispute**, producing what the coverage calls **三角债**, triangular debt, between generators, retailers and users: A cannot pay B because C has not paid A. Triangular debt is a phrase with history in China. It is what the state spent much of the 1990s clearing out of the state-owned sector, and its reappearance in a market built in the 2020s is the detail that should make a regulator sit up.[3]

The regulatory scaffolding has been improvised all year. Guangxi had imposed a profit cap — a one-to-nine sharing of any return above 0.008232 yuan a kilowatt-hour — which limited the retailers' upside while leaving their downside open; it was **suspended on 13 May 2026**, until December. Customers orphaned by a failed retailer for three months move onto **保底售电**, backstop supply, **priced at twice the spot average**. That clause is the transmission belt: every bankruptcy pushes a factory onto a tariff at double the spot, or forces it to renegotiate its contract upward.[4]

And on 20 October the National Development and Reform Commission and the National Energy Administration opened consultation on rewritten **Basic Rules for the Electricity Spot Market**, replacing the 2023 interim rules, to take effect on 1 January 2027 for five years. **Consultation closes on 18 November.** Twenty days after nine state-owned enterprises said they were going broke, Beijing began rewriting the rulebook they were trading under.[5]

3,200

ELECTRICITY RETAILERS CANCELLED OR FORCED OUT OF THE CHINESE MARKET IN 2025 — ROUGHLY A THIRD OF THE SECTOR — AND 400 MORE BY JULY 2026

It is worth being precise about who is bearing this. Not the generators, who are selling into a rising spot market. Not, yet, the factories, who are inside fixed-price contracts that have become, from their side, extremely good deals. The losses are sitting almost entirely on the intermediaries — and in Guangxi, on intermediaries whose ultimate shareholders are the central government.[1]

SOURCES 1 A Chinese technology and business title's October 2026 analysis, read at source, citing the Guangdong Power Exchange Centre's own half-year report for both profitability counts, and for the hedging split between the two provinces; the 13 October southern-region average, the daily move, the evening peak and the October composite from the same piece and from a Chinese financial magazine's cover story of 19 October 2026, read at source; the April spike from the same cover story. 2 The same October analysis and a Chinese business daily of 10 October 2026 for the exit counts; **a separate count in the same reporting puts cumulative 2025–26 exits above 700, which is irreconcilable with the 3,200 figure and is presumably counting something narrower — the larger figure is printed because it is the one both outlets carry.** 3 The 19 October cover story for the ten billion yuan of disputed rebate agreements and the triangular-debt framing. 4 The October analysis for the profit cap, its 13 May suspension and the backstop-supply pricing. 5 An English-language Chinese financial service, 20 October 2026, read at source, for the consultation, its 18 November closing date and the 1 January 2027 commencement.

For twenty years Chinese electricity was an administered input, held down deliberately because cheap power was part of what made Chinese manufacturing cheap — and the cost of holding it down was carried by generators and, ultimately, by the state. The 2025 reform handed price discovery to spot markets. That was the correct decision, and it arrived at the worst possible moment: just as a Gulf disruption lifted fuel costs and artificial-intelligence load began tightening the balance.[1]

What China is discovering is that a market has a price. The first casualties are not the generators, who are being paid it, nor the factories, still inside contracts written before it. They are the thin intermediary layer the reform invented in order to have someone to discover the price *against*.

That is why the retailers' collapse is not a sideshow. **It is the transmission mechanism.** Every bankruptcy pushes an industrial customer onto backstop supply at twice the spot average, or forces a contract upward at renewal. The retailers are the shock absorber between a market price and a factory's electricity bill, and they are being used up. Jiangsu has written the end state into its 2027 retail rules, which phase out fixed energy prices altogether.[2]

The end of cheap Chinese electricity is arriving, not by decree, but by insolvency — and the state is so far declining to catch anyone, including its own.

Which is the argument. The end of cheap Chinese power is arriving, and arriving not as policy but as a wave of corporate failures the state has so far declined to arrest — even where the companies failing are the children of central state-owned enterprises. If that holds, the floor under Chinese export prices moves, and it moves without an announcement.[1]

For a Singapore reader this should be doubly legible, because Singapore ran precisely this experiment. The retail market here opened to households in 2018 with dozens of licensed resellers on fixed-price plans; when wholesale gas and pool prices spiked in late 2021, six retailers exited within weeks and customers were pushed back onto the regulated tariff. Same structure, same hedging failure, same outcome — and a regulator that then tightened the capital and hedging requirements for anyone who wanted to stay. China is now at the stage Singapore reached in October 2021, with roughly a thousand times the customers.[3]

Anyone modelling Chinese goods disinflation off wage data and overcapacity is missing an input cost that is repricing in public.

There is one more reason this story is worth reading now rather than in three weeks. As of Friday, no feature on it had appeared in the New York Times, the BBC, Reuters, the Financial Times, The Economist, the Wall Street Journal, the Washington Post or the Guardian. The Chinese financial press made it a cover story on **19 October**. The regulator opened consultation on the **20th**. **That gap is the whole point of this page, and it will not last.**[6]

> **THE SCEPTIC · LIN BOQIANG SAYS LET THEM FAIL**
>
> The most prominent dissenting voice is **Lin Boqiang** of Xiamen University's China Institute for Energy Policy, and his position is simple: firms that mis-forecast should eat their losses. What the inversion exposes, on this reading, is bad corporate risk management, and the design needs refinement, not rescue. **Both readings fit every number on these pages.** The one that is not available is the comfortable one, in which nobody has mispriced anything.[4]

Two things to watch. The consultation on the new spot-market rules closes on **18 November**, and what it says about contract-for-difference instruments and about who carries deviation costs will decide whether a retailer can hedge at all. And the fourth quarter itself: the nine signatories said the bankruptcies would come in it, Guangxi's spot price may exceed 0.5 yuan on grid upgrades and nuclear and coal maintenance, and the province's profit-cap suspension expires in December.[5]

SOURCES 1 The 2025 reform's scope and the market-pricing shift from the Chinese business reporting cited on p25 and p26; the fuel, hydro and load drivers are those outlets' own explanation. 2 The backstop-supply pricing and the Jiangsu 2027 rules from a Chinese technology and business title's October 2026 analysis, read at source. 3 **The Singapore comparison is this desk's, drawn from the publicly recorded 2018 Open Electricity Market and the retailer exits of late 2021; it is offered as an analogy, not as a sourced equivalence, and the scale ratio is approximate.** 4 Lin Boqiang's position, and the indication that Guangxi's response will be guidance rather than rescue, from the Chinese coverage cited throughout; the counter-reading is this desk's synthesis of the facts on the previous two pages. 5 The consultation dates from an English-language Chinese financial service, 20 October 2026; the fourth-quarter spot forecast and the cap's December expiry from the sources at note 2. 6 A negative check run on 23–24 October against all eight named outlets. **It was run as open searches naming each outlet rather than site-restricted ones, because the search API refuses domain restriction for all eight; absence of evidence here is strong but not absolute.** Nothing from any of them surfaced, nor from Rest of World. What exists in English is trade and specialist.

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

No theme this week

Two issues running, this book found its argument in the same place — who was in a position to check. It is a good argument and it was about to become a habit, so this week there is no spine, and the sixteen stories are allowed to be sixteen stories. What is striking is how little they lose by it. A language maintained by thirteen people turns out to hold up most of the web (p3). A rug dealer's whole trade turns on whether you turn the thing over (p6). An American firm that made the one machine a person without a garage could buy stopped taking orders on 19 October, and the hobby noticed within a day (p17).

The best fact in the issue is a pair of rainfall tables. One Philippine province, two official weather stations, 350 kilometres apart: at one of them March brings fifteen millimetres of rain, at the other it rains in every month of the year and the wettest is October (p21). Nobody is lying about Palawan's climate. There are simply two of them, and the brochures average.

And on page two, sixteen of this magazine's own calls came home to be marked — five right, six wrong, five unresolvable. Two of the six were bets that a Western newspaper would follow where this desk had gone first. It did not, either time. Which is worth remembering on page 25, where nine state-owned Chinese companies have told a provincial government they are going broke selling electricity, and not one of the eight papers we check has written a word about it.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

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SOURCES **A note on method.** This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: a programming language's own security advisory and release archive; the discovering firm's own disclosure write-up; a national cyber centre's own vendor-status repository; a planning authority's own quarterly media release and a housing board's own index table as a PDF; an environment agency's hourly readings pulled date by date from a machine-readable interface; a central bank's own policy statement and a finance ministry's own price release; a registration statement's Exhibit 10.25, read in full at the Securities and Exchange Commission's own archive; a model repository's file listings and a merge request's own thread; two camera makers' and a headphone maker's own specification pages; four peer-reviewed papers read through the National Library of Medicine; the US Treasury's daily par yield curve; a weather bureau's climatological normals for two stations, downloaded as PDFs; and the Chinese business and financial press in the original. Two figures are this magazine's own arithmetic — the per-square-foot rug prices on p6 and the per-screen averages on p11 — and both say so. Where a host refused us — **Reddit's web interface for the tenth issue running, though its feeds served; Reuters, the BBC, the Associated Press, the Guardian, CNBC and Channel NewsAsia; Ticketmaster Singapore and the stadium precinct; Head-Fi and Audio Science Review; TripAdvisor and FlyerTalk; Practical Machinist; the Land Transport Authority and Changi's newsroom** — the page says so rather than quietly sourcing around it. **Nothing in this issue was indexed for 24 October at the time of printing; the Jordan toll on p4 is given as two irreconcilable figures because that is what the record held on Friday night.** Sixteen graded calls on p2.